

UNIT THREE

POLITICS, ECONOMY AND SOCIETY IN ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN TO THE END OF THE THIRTEENTH CENTURY (6 hours)

Introduction

From ancient times to the end of the thirteenth century, societies in Ethiopia and the Horn underwent political, economic, social and cultural changes. One remarkable change in the period was the evolution of states with diverse socio-cultural and economic settings. While agriculture and trade contributed to the evolution of states, religions shaped the socio-cultural setup of the states in different parts of Ethiopia and the Horn. The results of the period were socio-cultural achievements such as architecture, writing, calendar, numerals etc. Furthermore, the unit explains the external relations of the period that had significant role in shaping the history of region.

Unit Objectives

At the end of this unit, students will be able to:

- show the evolution of states in Ethiopia and the Horn;
- identify the factors for the rise and developments of the prominent ancient states;
- examine the relations among these states and the effects thereof;
- explicate the external relations of the period;
- elucidate socio-economic and cultural achievements of the period.

Unit Starters

- What does a state mean?
- Can you name some of the earliest states in Ethiopia and the Horn?
- Tell how Ethiopian people in different geographical locations maintained relationships.
- Explain how religion facilitates peoples' relations.

3.1. Emergence of States

One important factor for the emergence of states was the beginning of sedentary agriculture. Peoples had to descend from mountainsides to build houses near cultivated plots fencing both farming fields and residences, and harvested crops had to be stored and protected from humidity and rodents. Families preferred to live together forming larger communities for better security and to help each other in hard works. Using stick or hoe for planting was gradually replaced by ox-drawn plough and farmers acquired surplus produce to exchange with better tools and clothes with the artisans who were able to specialize in the production of these items. Gradually, intermediaries (traders) also began to buy the products of both to take to predetermined places or markets for exchange. Therefore, states were formed mainly through the expansion of agriculture that gave rise to class differentiation. Furthermore, the growth of trade facilitated the development of states.

State refers to an autonomous political unit having population, defined territory, sovereignty and government with the power to decree and enforce laws. State was the outcome of regular cultural process. In this regard, it should be emphasized that, states arose independently in different places and at different times. Favorable environmental conditions helped to hasten the rate of transformation in some regions. Religious leaders such as shamans played prominent role in maintaining the social and religious affairs of their people during the initial formation of the states. As production became market oriented, religious elites were gradually replaced by chiefs, who began collecting regular and compulsory tributes which amounted to protection payments with which they maintained themselves, their supporters chiefly the army, the bureaucracy and other followers.

Ethiopia and the Horn is one of the regions in Africa where early state formation took place. From small beginnings, such states gradually developed into powerful kingdoms and even empires with a well-demarcated social structure. Geographical proximity to and control of the international water bodies like Red Sea, Gulf of Aden and Indian Ocean along with their ports as well as rich interior favored some of them to become stronger than their neighbors and eventually dominated them.

3.2. Ancient States

3.2.1. North and Northeast

A. Punt

Punt was the earliest recorded state in Ethiopia and the Horn. The evidence on Punt comes from Egyptian hieroglyphic writings, accompanied by vivid paintings that describes series of naval expeditions, which the Egyptian Pharaohs sent to Punt. Pharaoh Sahure (r. 2743-2731 B.C.) sent expedition to collect myrrh, ebony and electrum (gold and silver alloy). During Pharaoh Asosi, treasurer of God Bawardede took dancing dwarf "dink" to Egypt from Punt.

The best described and illustrated expedition was the one undertaken by the order of the famous Egyptian Queen Hatshepsut (1490-1468 B.C.), whose expedition is documented at her tomb in Dier El Bahri. She sent five ships under the leadership of Black Nubian Captain Nehasi via Wadi-Tumilat. The expedition was warmly welcomed by the Puntites King Perehu, his wife Ati, sons, daughters and followers. The expedition was able to return collecting frank incense, cinnamon, sweet smelling woods (sandal), spices, ivory, rhinoceros horn, leopard and leopard skins, ostrich feathers and egg, live monkeys, giraffes, people etc. Hatshepsut presented some parts of the items to her god, Amun. It was because of the ritual importance of their exports that Puntites were also known as Khebis of the Ta Netjeru (divine or ghosts land). Iron, bronze, asses, foxes, cattle, animals fur, dying and medicinal plants were also exported from Punt to Egypt. In return, axes, daggers, swords, knives, sickles, clothes, bracelets, necklaces, beads and other trinkets were imported from Egypt to Punt.

Scholars have not reached agreement as to the exact location of Punt. The varieties of incense and myrrh mentioned in the writings have suggested northern or northeastern Somalia to some scholars while others are inclined more towards Northern Ethiopia because of the reference to gold, ebony and monkeys. The latter reinforce their guess arguing that at that early period, Egyptian sailboats might not have been strong enough to pass through the Strait of Bab-el Mandeb into the Gulf of Aden and the Indian Ocean. Considering the two suggestions, still some others argue that it probably stretched from Swakim or Massawa to Babel Mandeb (Gate of Tears) and Cape Guardafui.

B. Da'amat and Other Cultural Centers in Northern Ethiopia and Eritrea

The state known as Da'amat had a center a little to the south of Aksum. Inscription of the king of Da'amat tentatively dated to the fifth century BC shows that he used politico-religious title known as *Mukarib*. Various gods and goddesses like *Almouqah* (principal god), *Astarr* (Venus god), *Na'uran* (light god), *Shamsi* (sun god), and *Sin* (moon god) were worshipped in the domain of the Da'amat state and other northern Ethiopian pre-Aksumite cultural centers. There were similar practices in South Arabia at the time.

There were a number of cultural centers in northern Ethiopia. The major ones are:

- **Yeha:** is located 30 kms to the northeast of Aksum and was the oldest of these centers. It probably emerged around 1, 000 BC as a small emporium where South Arabian merchants and their agents bought and stored ivory, rhinoceros horn and other commodities coming from the interior. It seems that the period of its prosperity (zenith) was from about 750 to 500 B.C. Remains of walls of some of its buildings and stone masonry as well as still standing temple and inscriptions indicate Yeha's glory.
- **Hawulti Melazo:** is situated to southeast of Aksum, where stone tablets that are inscribed in rectangular temple surrounded by a wall decorated with paintings representing herds of cattle have been excavated.
- **Addi-Seglemani:** is located at 10kms southwest of Aksum, from where a stone slab is found and the oldest Ethiopian monumental inscription is discovered.

There were also other cultural centers like Addi Gelemo, Addi Grameten, Addi Kewih, Atsbi Dera, Feqiya, Hinzat, Sefra, Senafe, Tekonda etc.

C. The Aksumite State

The nucleus of the Aksumite state was formed around 200-100 B.C. Initially, its power was limited to a relatively small area comprising the town of Aksum and its environs. Gradually, however, it expanded to include large territories in all directions. In its heyday, Aksumite territories extended from the Red Sea coast in the East to the Western edge of Ethiopian plateau overlooking the vast Nile Valley in the west and from the northern most corner of Eritrea and possibly as far south as northern parts of Shewa.

According to *Periplus of Erithrean Sea*, Adulis on the western coast of the Red Sea was the major port of Aksum. The long distance trade routes from Adulis and other posts on the Red Sea coast passed inland through such centers as Kaskasse, Coloe, Matara and even further west across Takaze River. The document also mentioned ports of Aden (Eudaemon) Gulf like Avalites (Zayla) and Malao (Berbera), and Indian Ocean Benadir Coasts like Serapion (Moqadishu), Nikon (Brava) and Merca. The major items of export of the Aksumite state consisted mainly of the natural products such as ivory, myrrh, emerald, frankincense and some spices (like ginger, cassia and cinnamon), gold, rhinoceros horns, hippopotamus hides, tortoise shells and some curiosity animals like apes. In turn, a number of manufactured products like garments and textiles from Egypt, India, the Roman Empire, and Persia; glassware and jewelry from Egypt and other places; metallic sheets, tools or utensils of various kinds, oil and wine from the regions of Roman Empire and Syria were imported. Zoscales (c. 76-89), the then king of Aksum, used to speak the Greek language, the Lingua Franca of Greco-Roman world. Aksum also had relations with Ceylon (Sri Lanka) and Laodicea (Asia Minor).

The Adulis inscription written in Greek about an unknown king, which eventually was published in Cosmas Indicopleustes' book, the *Christian Topography*, describes commercial activities of the Red Sea areas. It also mentions the internal long distance trade between Aksum and a distant region called Sasu, most probably in Beni Shangul and the adjoining lands beyond the Blue Nile. A big caravan made up of close to five hundred merchants some of them special agents of the kings of Aksum would take to Sasu cattle, lumps of salt (probably salt blocks) and iron to exchange for gold. Yet, as they did not speak each other's language, and did not even trust to be near to each other to bargain through signs and gestures, the whole exchange was done without one side seeing the other. This was a good example of silent trade.

Aksumite kings had extensive contacts with the outside world notably with the South Arabian region, leading to exchange of ideas, material and spiritual culture. Sometimes such contacts involved conflicts between the two regions. One of such known recorded conflict between areas on both sides of the sea took place around 200 A.D. Accordingly, peoples in

Southern Arabian Peninsula, in present day Yemen, had difficulties in defending themselves against the army of the Aksumite king, Gadarat.

From the third to the seventh centuries, Aksumite kings like Aphilas, Endybis, Wazeba, Ezana, Ousanas II, etc. minted and issued different kinds of coins in gold, silver and bronze for both overseas and local transactions.

Aksum was one of the four great powers of the world (i. e. Roman Empire, Persia, China and Aksum) at the time. It was a major naval and trading power from the first to the seventh centuries. Aksumite ships were the main means of transporting goods. Aksum was the only one with sufficient sources of timber for ship building and in those days, the technology for it existed in Adulis. Aksum had a large fleet of ships, which was used not only for trade but also for its wars across the Red Sea.

Kaleb (r. 500-35) expanded overseas territories of Aksum beyond Himyar and Saba, but the local prince Dhu-Nuwas was converted to Judaism, marched to Zafar and Nagran, and killed many Christians. Byzantine Vasaliev Justinian (r. 527-65) with sanctification of Patriarch Timit III (518-538) provided Kaleb with a number of ships to transport armies led by Julianos and Nonossus against Dhu Nuwas. Dhu Nuwas was defeated and Kaleb appointed Abraha as governor of Arabia that continued until 570 A. D. Kaleb was succeeded by his son Gabra Masqal (535-48) who built a church at Zur Amba in Gayint. It was during Gabra Maskal that Yared developed Ethiopian Orthodox Church liturgical songs and hymns.

The Aksumite state began to decline since the late seventh century because of internal and external challenges. Environmental degradation, decline in agricultural productivity and possibly plague infestation started to weaken it. With the destruction of the port of Adulis by the Arabs around 702, the international lifeline of the state was cut. The whole network of Aksumite international trade came under the control of the rising and expanding Arab Muslims, isolating the Aksum state from its old commercial and diplomatic partners. Consequently, the Aksumite state declined economically. This naturally led to the decline of its political and military power not only on the Red Sea coast but also in its interior provinces, where Aksumite hegemony was challenged by local rebellions. The recurring

rebellions of the Beja, the Agaw and Queen Bani al Hamwiyah (Yodit) finally sealed the collapse of the Aksumite state.

However, as a civilization, Aksum had a profound impact upon the peoples of the Horn of Africa and beyond, and on its successors i.e. the Zagwe, 'Solomonic Dynasty', the Gondarine period etc. Some of its achievements include Sub-Saharan Africa's only surviving indigenous script and calendar as well as EOC hymns and chants, paintings etc; diversified ceramic and lithic tools, ivory curving, and urbanization and sophisticated building traditions (palaces, stele, rock-hewn churches...). It also developed complex administrative and governance system, and agricultural system including irrigation etc.

D. Zagwe Dynasty

After its decline, the center of Aksumite state shifted southwards to Kubar rural highland in the territory of the Agaw, one of the ancient inhabitants of the land between the Eritrean Plateau and Jema River, and to the west up to the Blue Nile valleys. This apparently gave Agaw elites the opportunity to take part in Aksumite state structure serving as soldiers and functionaries for at least four centuries. After integrating so well with Aksumite ruling class, they successfully tookover the state administration. Accordingly, the Agaw prince Merra Teklehaimanot married Masobe Worq, the daughter of the last Aksumite king Dil Na'od. Later he overthrew his father-in-law and took control of power. Merra-Teklehaimanot's successors include Yimirahana Kirstos, Harbe, Lalibela (1160-1211), Ne'akuto La'ab, Yetbarek etc. Notwithstanding the debates, the Zagwe Dynasty is believed to have ruled from c. 1150 to 1270.

The Zagwe Dynasty made its center in Bugna District within Wag and Lasta, more exactly at Adafa near Roha (Lalibela). The territory of the Zagwe kingdom extended from most of the highland provinces of the ancient Aksumite kingdom in the north down to northern Shewa in the south, the Lake Tana region and the northern part of what is today Gojjam in the west.

The Agaw maintained the ancient Aksumite traditions almost intact. Zagwe rulers renewed cultural and trade contact with eastern Mediterranean region. The most important export

items included slaves, ivory and rare spices while cotton, linen, silver and copper vessels, various types of drags and newly minted coins were imported.

Furthermore, the Zagwe period was a golden age in Ethiopia's paintings and the translation of some religious works from Arabic into Ge'ez. That said, Zagwe rulers are best known for the construction of cave, semi-hewn and monolithic churches:

- 1. Cave:** with some decoration inside, almost similar with natural cave, eg. Bete-Mesqel.
- 2. Semi-hewn:** this and the monolithic churches that have become UNESCO world heritage are unique in constructions. Semi-hewan are with detailed interior decoration and partial decoration outside. They are not totally separated from the surrounding rock. Their roofs or walls are still attached to the rock, eg. Bete Denagil, Bete Debresina/Mikael, Bete Golgota, Bete Merqoriwos, Bete Gabri'el-Rufa'el and Bete Abba Libanos.
- 3. Monolithic:** with detailed decoration in the interior and exterior parts. They are completely separated (carved out) from surrounding rock, eg. Bete Amanuel, Bete Giyorgis, Bete Mariyam and Bete Medhanialem.

Among the eleven churches of Lalibela, Bete Medhanelem is the largest of all and Bete Giyorgis is said to be the most finely built in the shape of the Cross.

Lalibela wanted to establish the second Jerusalem, and mitigate or even avoid difficulties, which Ethiopian Christians encountered in their journey to the Holy Lands. This was done by constructing churches based on the model of Holy Lands in Israel.

The Zagwe Dynasty came to end due to internal problems of royal succession and oppositions from groups claiming descent from the ancient rulers of Aksum. The latter considered Zagwe kings "illegitimate rulers" based on the legend of the Queen of Sheba. The legend was in turn based on a book known as *Kebra-Negest* (Glory of Kings) that was translated from Coptic to Arabic and then into Ge'ez. Based on the legend, the power claimants contend that "Solomonic" Dynasty ruled the Aksumite state until its power was "usurped" by the Zagwes. Yekuno-Amlak (r. 1270-1285), who claimed decent from the last Aksumite king Dilna'od, organized his forces with the assistance of the ecclesiastical hierarchy and engaged the last king of Zagwe, Yetbarek in battle. Yetbarek was killed in

Gaynt and Yekuno-Amlak took the state power proclaiming the “restoration” of “Solomonic” Dynasty.

3.2.2. East, Central, Southern, and Western States

3.2.2.1. Bizamo, Damot, Enarya and Gafat

A. Bizamo: was a kingdom located on the southern bend of Abay River just opposite to the present districts of Gojjam and around the current Wambara area. It was founded in the eighth century and had early connections with Damot.

B. Damot: was a strong kingdom that expanded its territories into most of the lands the south of Abay and north of Lake Turkana as well as west of Awash and east of Didessa. Motalami was a prominent king of Damot in the thirteenth century.

C. Enarya: was a kingdom in the Gibe region in southwestern Ethiopia. The royal clan was Hinnare Bushasho (Hinnario Busaso). Enarya's kingship was a divine one: the king (Hinnare-Tato) was secluded and considered as sacred. He communicated with visitors through an intermediary, *AfeBusho*. The real power rested with *Mikretcho* (council) including *Awa-rasha* (king's spokesperson) and *Atche-rasha* (royal treasurer). The kings had residences in Yadare and Gowi. In the ninth century, Aksumite king Digna-Jan is said to have led a campaign into Enarya, accompanied by Orthodox Christian priests carrying arks of covenant (*tabots*).

D. Gafat: historically, the territory of Gafat lies south of Abay (Blue Nile) River adjoining Damot on the south western periphery of the Christian Kingdom. It was inhabited by Semitic speaking population related to Harari and the Gurage. It is not clear from available records whether the Gafat formed a “state” or not, but Gafat mountains provided a rich source of gold. Despite efforts by Christian evangelists, the Gafat largely remained practitioners of their own indigenous religion. As of early medieval period, Gafat was paying tribute to the Christian Kingdom mainly in cattle, which came from six districts, among which Gambo and Shat are Gafat clan names. The state was governed by rulers bearing the title of *Awalamo*.

3.2.2.2. Muslim Sultanates

After the spread of Islam since the beginning of the eighth century, viable Muslim communities and states had been established at many locations especially along the main trade routes from Zeila and its many branches penetrating the interior. These states include:

- A. **Shewa:** Makhzumi Khalid ibn al-Walid, who claimed decent from Meca, set up the Makhzumite Sultanate in 896 A. D (283 A.H.) on northeastern foothill of Shewa.
- B. **Fatagar:** was founded around Minjar, Shenkora and Ada'a in the eleventh century. It was a hilly lowland area with thoroughly cultivated fields of wheat and barley, fruits, and extensive grazing grounds full of numerous herds of cattle, sheep and goats.
- C. **Dawaro:** located south of Fatagar between upper waters of Awash and Wabi-Shebelle extending to Charchar in Northeast and Gindhir in Southeast. We have valuable information on Dawaro by an Egyptian courtier Ibn Fad Allah el-umari. It was much smaller than Ifat, but resembled it in many aspects. Dawaro had a currency called *hakuna* for transaction .
- D. **Bali:** was an extensive kingdom occupying high plateau, separating basins of Shebelle and Rift valley Lakes. It was separated from Dawaro by the Wabi-Shebelle River and extended southwards to the Gannale Dirre River. Bali was one of the largest of Ethiopia's Muslim provinces. Its economic activity resembles those of other nearby Muslim lands. Trade was mainly based on barter exchanging cattle, sheep, cloth etc. It had strong army composed of cavalry and infantry.
- E. **Ifat:** was a state located adjacent to Shewan Sultanate. Its territory ran from northeast-southwesterly in the Afar plain eastward to the Awash. It was established by Umar Walasma, who claimed descent t from Hashamite clan and said to have come from Arabia between 1271 and 1285. He intervened between quarrelsome Makzumite princes Dil-Marrah and Dil-Gamis, weakened and annexed the sultanate of Shewa. The sultanate was fertile and well watered. Its inhabitants earned their living from cultivation of wheat, sorghum, millet and *teff*, and animal husbandry. Sugar cane, bananas, variety of fruits, beans, squashes, cucumbers, and cabbage completed the diet. *Chat* was described for the first time as being consumed as a stimulant.

- F. **Others:** autonomous states mutually independent states like Arababani (between Hadiya and Dawwaro), Biquizar, Dera (between Dawaro and Bali), Fadise, Gidaya, Hargaya, Harla, Kwilgora, Qadise, Sharkah (West of Dawaro and North of Bali in Arsi) and Sim were established and flourished.

3.3. External Contacts

Ethiopia and the Horn had contacts with Egypt since at least 3,000 B. C. These relations may be the region's earliest contacts with the Mediterranean world or the Greco-Roman World. It had very close relations with all commercially active South Arabian Kingdoms starting sometimes before 1,000 B.C. The introduction of Christianity to Aksum established a new pattern of relation between the region and Egypt. Until the introduction of Islam into Egypt and the general reduction of the Christians into minority, relations between the two were fairly smooth and friendly. Following the introduction of Christianity, Aksum established close relationship with the East Roman or Byzantine Empire with which it shared common commercial interest in the Red Sea area against their rival Persians. Yet, in the seven century, this relation became complicated and began to deteriorate. The rapid expansion of the Muslim Arabs through the Near and Middle East, North Africa and the Nile valley led to the decline of Aksumite land routes and shipping lines. Successive Egyptian Muslim rulers began to use the consecration and sending of a bishop as an instrument to further their own foreign policy objectives and to squeeze concessions from Ethiopian Christian rulers, who reacted by threatening to divert the Nile. The coming to power of the Mamluk was followed by the reciprocal persecution of religious minorities. Moreover, the Mamluk presented a barrier to the contacts between Christian Ethiopia and European states.

However, the tradition to visit Jerusalem and other holy places in the Middle East had begun at the end of the first millennium AD. In order to reach the places, Ethiopian Christian pilgrims used the land route to Egypt. From Cairo, again they used the land route to the Holy land. Consequently, there were considerable numbers of Ethiopian Christian communities found in different regions, in Egyptian monasteries, in the holy places of Palestine and Armenia, and in Italian city-states in subsequent centuries. The communities living in different parts of the world served as an important link or bridge between Ethiopian Christian Kingdom and Europe. When pilgrims met their fellow Christians of Europe in the holy

places, they transmitted information about the EOC and its exceptional liturgical practices. They also explained about the territorial extent of the Christian Kingdom.

From the information, the Europeans began to consider Ethiopian Christian Kingdom as a very powerful and wealthy state existing in the Horn of Africa. Consequently, they wanted to use this imaginary strong Christian power in their struggle against the Muslim powers in the Holy land. Around the middle of the 12th century, a myth about a very rich and powerful Christian ruler known as Prester *John* began to circulate in Europe. The legend was developed when the balance of the crusade war fought over Jerusalem between the Christians of Europe and the Muslims of the Middle East was in favor of the latter. In 1165, a letter addressed to European kings, thought to be sent by the Prester John appeared in Europe mentioning about the enormous power of the Prester John. The geographical location of the country of Prester John was not known to Europe for over a century. However, the Europeans began to regard Ethiopian Christian Kingdom as the land of Prester John since the only Christian kingdom between the Red Sea and the Indian sub-continent was the Ethiopian Christian Kingdom. Then, they began to search for the location of the Kingdom and to make an alliance with it.

3.4. Economic Formations

A. Agriculture and Land Tenure System

The main stay of ancient states' economy in highland areas was plough agriculture. The mastery of the technology of irrigation also contributed to the growth of agricultural production. Small valley head wetlands were drained for dry season cultivation. The people used diverse soil fertility enhancement strategies like manuring, compost and spreading residues' ashes as well as fallowing, crop rotation, intercropping and contour plowing. In times of peak harvest seasons, farmers also organized teamwork.

Land has always been one of the most precious possessions of human society throughout history. The rules according to which members of the society hold, share and use land constitute what is known as the land tenure system. The most ancient system of land holding which survived in many parts of Ethiopia and the Horn is the communal land tenure system. Communal right to land is a group right. Here group refers to the family, the clan and the

other lineage groups to which the individual belonged. Each of these groups had communal right to the land they lived in and freely exploited the resources of the land.

Peasants in the north had *rist* rights in their respective areas. *Rist* is a kind of communal birthright to land by members of the families and clans whose ancestors had settled and lived in the area over long periods. It is inherited from generation to generation in accordance to customary law. Most of the subjects of the state had *rist* rights. The *rist* owners were known as *bale-rist*. Yet, they paid tributes to the state and all land belonged to the state theoretically. Tribute was collected through a complex hierarchy of state functionaries or officials who were given *gult* right over the areas and populations they administered on behalf of the central government. *Gult* is a right to levy tribute on *rist* owners' produce. The tribute collected by *bale-gults*, partly allotted for their own up keep and the rest were sent to the imperial center. *Gult* right that became hereditary was called *Riste-Gult* as prominent well-placed officials used to transfer their position to their offspring.

B. Handicraft

Indigenous handcraft technology had existed since the ancient period. The social, economic and political conditions of ancient states had allowed the emergence of artisans in various fields with diverse forms and applications including metal work, pottery, tannery, carpentry, masonry, weaving, jewelry, basketry and others. Metal workers produced spears' points, swords, javelins, bows, arrows, traps, slings, slashers, shields, knives, axes, sickles, hoes, ploughshares, spades, machetes, hatchets, iron tripods, ornaments etc. Carpenters engaged in carving wood implements like doors, windows, stools, chairs, tables, beds, headrests, mortars, bowls, beams, yoke, stilt, coffins etc while potters produced ceramic utensils like saucepan, ovens, jar, pot, kettle, cooking tripod, plates, granary etc. Tanners produced leather tools used for bed, bed cover, saddles, harness, ropes, footwear, prayer mats, sacks, honey and butter container, drinking cup and clothes until replaced by weavers' cotton dresses.

However, except the carpenters and masons in some cases, the artisans were mostly despised and marginalized. The ruling classes mostly spent their accumulated wealth on imported luxurious items rather than the domestic technology. The general public attitude towards artisans was not at all encouraging. Consequently, the locally produced agricultural

implements and house furniture did not show any significant improvement and sophistication.

C. Trade

Trade was another important economic activity of ancient states that obtained considerable income from both internal and international trade. The major socio-economic and political centers of earliest states seem to have also been major trade centers with wide ranging contacts in various directions within the region itself and with merchants coming to the area across the international water bodies. A network of roads connected the centers with the coast and various dependencies in the interior. Local and international merchants frequented these roads. The region was crisscrossed by various trade routes connecting various market places in all directions. The regular flow of trade was so vital to the states in that one of their major concerns was to protect the trade routes and make them safe from robbers.

3.5. Socio-cultural Achievements

A. Architecture

As the states expanded, architecture also began to flourish and one of the unique architectural technologies was the engraving of stele around the third century AD. There were totally fifty eight steles in and around Aksum that can be grouped into well made and decorated, half completed and megaliths (not hewn). As local tradition says, the steles were engraved specifically at Gobodara from which they were transported and planted in Aksum. The longest one of these stele measures 33meters heights (the first in the world). It is highly decorated in all of its four sides. It represents a-14 storied building with many windows and a false door at the bottom. It also bears pre-Christian symbols, which are a disc and a crescent (half moon) at the top. Some scholars suggest that this giant stele was broken while the people were trying to erect it. The second longest obelisk measures 24 meters height that was successfully erected and represents a ten-storied building with many windows and a false door at the bottom. The third longest stele measures 21 meters and represents a nine-storied building with many windows and a false door at the bottom. It is smooth at the back of its side with no decoration.

Picture 2: The Second Longest Aksumite Stele



Source:<http://whc.unesco.org>, accessed on 8-1-2020.

The Zagwe churches are regarded as some of the finest architecture of artistic achievements of the Christian world and that is why they were registered by UNESCO as part of world cultural heritage in 1978, two years before that of the Aksumite stele. Further refinement can be observed in the construction and decoration of the rockhewn churches in the Zagwe period. Zagwe architecture used a softer material like sandstone, which was cut and shaped all round, except the floor, into a variety of delicately decorated churches.

Picture 3: One of the Zagwe Churches (Bete Giyorgis)



Source: wanderlust.co.uk, accessed on 21-1-2020.

B. Writing System

The Sabeian language had an alphabet with boustrophedon writing type that is paleographical writing from left to right and right to left alternatively. The earliest Sabeian inscriptions in Eritrea and Ethiopia date to the ninth century BC. One peculiar feature of Sabeian inscriptions is absence of vowels as most of the words are written in consonants. For instance, Da'amat was inscribed as D'mt, while its successive kings are written as RDM, RBH and LMN using title, mlkn.

After the seventh and sixth centuries BC, however, variants of script arose, evolving in the direction of the Ge'ez script (an alpha syllabary). This evolution can be seen most clearly in evidence from inscriptions mainly graffiti on rocks and caves. By the first century AD, "Ge'ez alphabet" arose, an *abjad* (26 consonant letters only) written left-to-right with letters identical to the first-order forms of modern vocalized alphabet.

Though the first completely vocalized texts known are inscriptions by Ezana (who left trilingual inscriptions in Greek, Sabeian and Ge'ez) c. 330 AD, vocalized letters predate him by some years, as vocalized letter exists in Wazeba's coin some 30 or so years before. The process was developed under the influence of Christian scripture by adding vocalic diacritics for vowels, u, i, a, e, ə, o, to the consonantal letters in a recognizable but slightly irregular way, so that the system is laid out as a syllabary.

Ethiopia's ancient indigenous writing system has immense contribution to the development of literature, art and the writing of history.

C. Calendar

People needed to know and remember the times when the rains would begin and end as well as the rise and fall of the water level. The responsibility of understanding these vital climatic cycles fell on expertise. In due course, calendars were invented. In most cases, the length of the month was based on the movement of the moon or the apparent movement of the sun. Otherwise, the number of days in the week or in the year varied from region to region.

Calendars were developed and adopted among various peoples of Ethiopia and the Horn. Oromo calendar has been based on astronomical observations of moon in conjunction with

seven or eight particular stars or group of stars called *Urjii Dhahaa* (guiding stars) and *Bakkalcha* (morning star). There are 29.5 dates in a month and 354 days in 12 months of a year. Pillars (dated 300 B.C.), which were discovered in northwestern Kenya from 1978-86 by Archaeologists Lynch, Robbins and Doyle have suggested to represent site used to develop Oromo calendar. In connection with this, c. 900 A. D. Oromo person Waqlim is said to have taken art of shaping phallic bowls to Zimbabwe.

The Sidama calendar rotates following movements of stars with 13 months a year, 12 of which are divided equally into 28 days while the thirteenth month has 29 days. The Sidama week has only 4 days (*Dikko, Dela, Qawado* and *Qawalanka*) and hence each month has 7 weeks. Nominated *Mote* (King) is presented to *Fiche Chambalala*, New Year ritual, for *Qetela* or popular demonstration.

Ethiopic solar calendar has 12 months of 30 days plus 5 or 6 (is added every 4 years) Epagomenal days, which comprise a thirteenth month. A gap of 7–8 years between Ethiopic and Gregorian calendars results from alternative calculation in determining date of Annunciation. Thus, the first day of the year, 1 *Meskerem/Enkutatash* is usually September 11 (Gregorian). However, it falls on September 12 in years before the Gregorian leap year. The Ethiopic solar calendar has evolved to become the official calendar of the country.

The Muslim (Islamic) calendar is a lunar calendar consisting of 12 months in a year of 354 or 355 days. It employs the *Hijra* year of 622 AD, in which Mohammed and his followers made flight from Mecca to Medina and established the first Muslim community (*ummah*). Dates in this era are usually denoted AH (After *Hijra*, "in the year of the *Hijra*"). Years prior to the *Hijra* are reckoned as BH ("Before the *Hijra*").

Other peoples like the Agaw, Halaba, Hadiya, Wolayta, Gedeo, the Nilotes, etc have their own dating system.

D. Numerals

Numerals appeared in Ethiopia and the Horn at the beginning of fourth century AD. Ge'ez uses numeral system comparable to the Hebrew, Arabic and Greek numerals, but it lacks individual characters for multiples of 100. Numbers are over- and underlined in proper

typesetting, combined to make a single bar, but some less sophisticated fonts cannot render this and show separate bars above and below each character.

Learning Activities

- Do further research in your library on the histories of ancient states of Ethiopia and the Horn and present your findings to the class. Make sure to address the what, where, when, why, how and by whom questions in your assignment.
- Explain the role of agriculture and trade in the formation and consolidation of ancient states of Ethiopia and the Horn. Use examples to illustrate your discussion.
- Discuss how Christianity and Islam expanded in Ethiopia and assess their importance in the political and cultural life of ancient states of the region.
- Discuss the debates surrounding the location of Punt.
- What differences did you observe between Aksumite stele and Egyptian pyramids?
- Discuss the origin and growth of the Aksumite state.
- Discuss outstanding political and cultural achievements of the Aksumite state.
- What did the states of Punt and Aksum have in common?
- Discuss internal and external factors for the decline and fall of Aksumite kingdom.
- What were the major reasons that led king Lalibela to construct rock-hewn churches?
- What was the significance of the legend of Queen of Sheba in Ethiopian politics?
- What factors brought the Zagwe dynasty to an end?
- Discuss the role of trade and trade routes in the interactions between peoples and states in Ethiopia and the Horn and assess the outcomes of these relationships.
- Sketch the major trade routes that linked northern and southern Ethiopia with the outside world.
- Explain how Ethiopian societies were both influenced by contact with the outside world while concurrently influencing external societies with whom they had contact.

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UNIT FOUR

POLITICS, ECONOMY AND SOCIETY FROM THE LATE THIRTEENTH TO THE BEGINNING OF THE SIXTEENTH CENTURIES (6 hours)

Introduction

The period from the late thirteenth to the beginning of the sixteenth centuries experienced dynamic political, economic, and socio-cultural developments that lay the foundation for the formation of modern Ethiopia in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. The "restoration" of the "Solomonic" Dynasty, succession problems, territorial expansion, evangelization, flourishing and development of trade as well as expansion of extensive socio-cultural interactions among different peoples who lived in different agro-ecological zones were some of the events that shaped the course of history in the region. This unit treats those events and shows the relationships that exist between them.

Unit Objectives

At the end of this unit, students will be able to:

- explain the concept of the “restoration” of “Solomonic” Dynasty;
- Explain the succession problems and the role of Amba Gishen in Christian Kingdom;
- scrutinize dynamics of territorial expansion of the Christian Kingdom;
- elaborate the relationship between trade and expansion of Islam in the region;
- identify the characteristics of inter-state relation during the period under discussion;
- identify the factors for interaction of the people of the region in the period;
- discuss the rivalry between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim Sultanates in the region;
- point out the nature of Ethiopia's relations with the outside world during the period.

Unit Starters

- What do you remember about the legend of the Queen of Sheba and its role in Ethiopian politics?
- What does territorial expansion mean?
- What do we mean by evangelization?
- What do you think are the roles of trade in a society?

4.1. The “Restoration” of the “Solomonic” Dynasty

The rulers of the “Solomonic” Dynasty claimed that they were descendants of the last king of Aksum and hence, they were legitimate to take over state power from the “illegitimate” rulers of the Zagwe dynasty. As the claim has no historical evidence, the name “Restoration” is put in quotation mark.

Similarly, the name “Solomonic” is placed in quotation marks because the claim of descent from King Solomon of Israel is legendary. The claim has been elaborated in the *Kibre Negest* (“Glory of Kings”) that associated Ethiopia with the Judeo-Christian tradition. The *Kibre Negest* claims that Ethiopian ruling class descended from the line of Menilek I, son of the Queen of Sheba and King Solomon of Israel. As a result, Ethiopian monarchs from Yikuno-Amlak to Emperor Haile-Silassie I claimed descent from Menilek I.

4.2. Power Struggle, Consolidation, Territorial Expansion and Religious Processes

4.2.1. Succession Problem and the Establishment of a ‘Royal Prison’ of Amba Gishen

Following the end of the reign of Yikuno-Amlak in 1285, a political instability caused by constant power struggles among his sons and grandsons for succession occurred. A letter written by Yegba-Tsion (r.1285-94) to the Sultan of Egypt and the Patriarch of Alexandria in 1290 reflected the existence of those struggles. The power struggle intensified during the reigns of Yegba-Tsion’s five sons who reigned from 1294 to 1299.

The succession problem seems to have been partly resolved in 1300 during the reign of Widim-Ra’ad (r. 1299-1314) following the establishment of a 'royal prison' at Amba-Gishen located in present day southern Wollo where all male members of the royal family were confined until one among them was installed in power. Loyal soldiers to the reigning monarch guarded the royal prison. When the monarch died, court dignitaries would send an army to the royal prison to escort the designated successor and put him on the throne. This practice continued until Amba-Gishen was destroyed by Imam Ahmad Ibrahim Al-Ghazi's force in 1540.

4.2.2. Consolidation and Territorial Expansion of the Christian Kingdom

From 1270 until the establishment of Gondar in 1636, the medieval monarchs had no permanent capital. Initially, the center of the “restored” dynasty was in medieval Amhara (today’s South Wollo) around Lake Haiq. However, it gradually shifted southward to the districts of Menz, Tegulet, Bulga, and finally to the regions dominated by the great height of the Yerer, Entoto, Menagesha, Wachacha, Furi and Zequalla mountains.

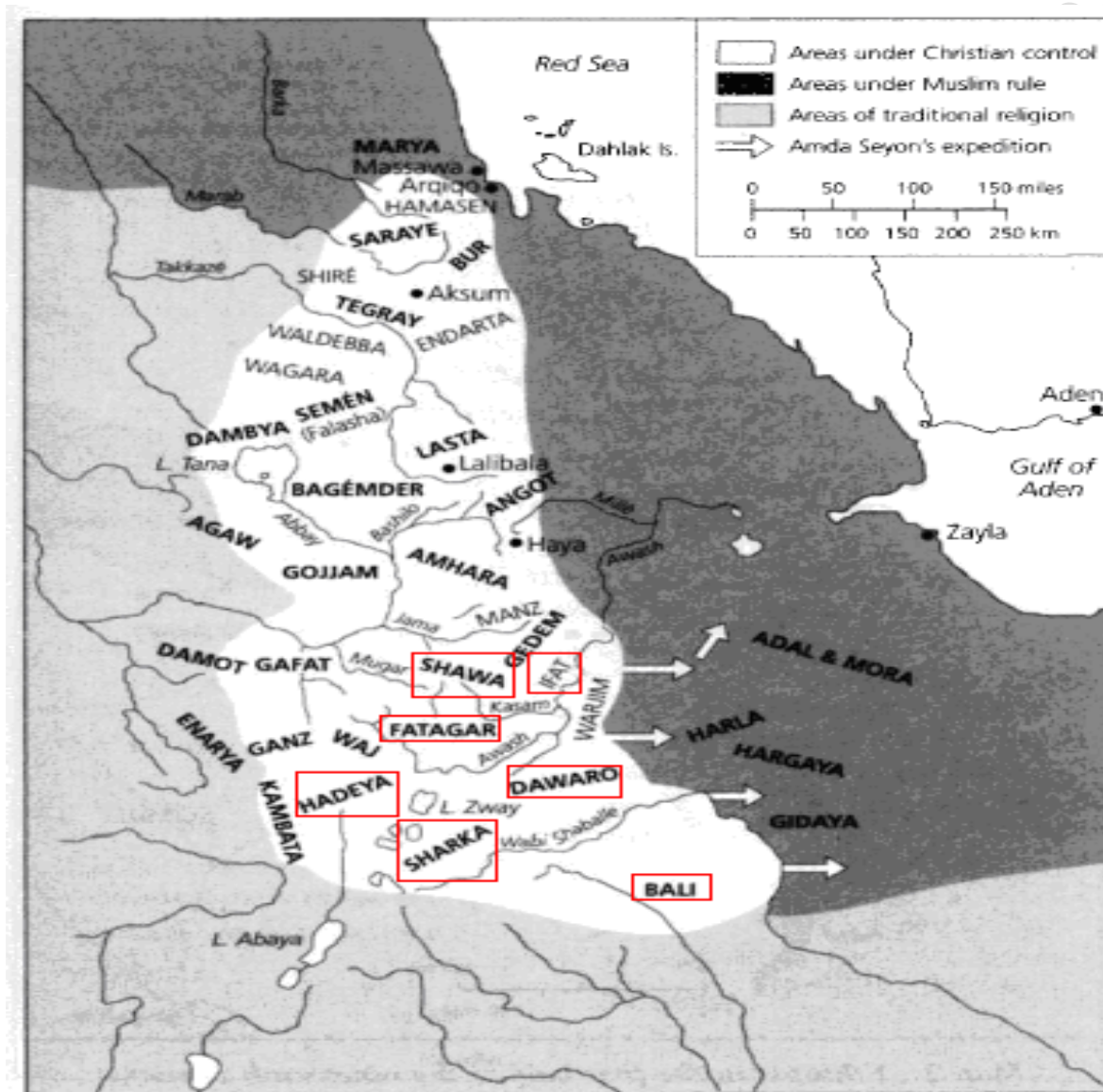
After coming to power, Yikuno-Amlak embarked on consolidating his authority throughout the empire. In this regard, he quickly subdued Ifat, the Muslim center adjacent to Shewa. Yet, until the coming of Amde-Tsion (r.1314-44), the center and the territorial limit of the Christian Kingdom was mainly in present day Tigray, Lasta, medieval Amhara and Shewa. Amde-Tsion was the first "Solomonic" King, who embarked on a policy of a wider and rapid territorial expansion. His main motives of expansion were economic and political i.e. to control the trade routes and seize territories. The Christian Kingdom controlled extensive territories during the reign of Emperor Amde-Tsion. The period also witnessed the expansion of trade leading to the flow of commodities to the coast following the major routes.

In the process of consolidating his power, Amde-Tsion subdued rebellions in an attempt to end centrifugal tendencies, which threatened the unity of the Christian Kingdom. In the process, he expanded his territory into Agaw (Awi) of Gojjam around 1323/4; Bizamo and Damot in 1316/7; Bete-Israel (located between Dambiya and Tekeze River) around 1332; and the Red Sea Coast. To consolidate the control of the Christian state over the provinces of the north extending to the coastal areas of Massawa, Amde-Tsion gave Enderta (in today’s northeastern Tigray) to his wife Bilen-Saba. Amde-Tsion's army faced stiff resistance from among Ifat and Shewa, which might have cooperated with the rebellious army at Enderta, led by Yibeka-Igzi in 1320s. However, Bahr-Sagad, the son of Amde-Tsion, became the governor of Tigray. In 1325, Amde-Tsion campaigned to today’s Eritrean region. After controlling the whole region, he appointed a governor with a title of *Ma'ekale-Bahir*, which later on changed to *Bahire-Negash*.

In the southeast, Muslim sultanates paid tributes to the Christian Kingdom. In the south, Gurage speaking areas and a few of the Omotic kingdoms like Wolayta and Gamo were

brought under the influence of the Christian state. Amde-Tsion was in full control of all the trade routes and sources of trade of the Ethiopian region in the early 1330s. The consolidation and territorial expansion of the Christian Kingdom continued during the successors of Amde-Tsion.

Map 3: The Christian Kingdom during the Reign of Emperor Amde-Tsion



Source: Taddesse Tamrat, *Church and State in Ethiopia*, p. 133.

4.2.3. Evangelization, Religious Movements, and Religious Reforms of Zara-Yaqob

I. Evangelization

Christianity had a long history of expansion. Churches and their believers had been in existence long before expansion of the Christian Kingdom in various parts of the Horn of Africa. For instance, in Shewa there were early Christians who maintained contacts with their distant relatives in Northern part of Ethiopia. Those early Christians played an important role in the spread of Christianity in several areas. In the thirteenth century, Eyesus-Mo'a opened new opportunities of learning for Christians who lived in the central part of Ethiopia and later evangelized the newly incorporated areas where the influence of Christianity had either been non-existent or minimal. The territorial expansion carried out by Amde-Tsion during the medieval period set an addition momentum for the spread of Christianity.

Abune Tekle-Haymanot (thirteenth century) played a key role in reviving Christianity in Shewa, which was followed by the evangelization of areas in southern Ethiopia including medieval Damot. He baptized and converted Motalami to Christianity. The clergy, under the direction of the bishop in Ethiopia, Yaqob, spread Christianity to different areas of Shewa such as Kil'at, Tsilalish, Merhabite, Wereb, Moret and Wegda, and Fatagar, Damot, Waj and Enarya.

II. Religious Movements

A. The Ewostatewos Movement

Monasticism became a dominant practice in Ethiopian Orthodox Church in the mid-thirteenth century. The period witnessed development of monasticism and religious movements of which the major one was the Ewostatewos movement, named after the founder. Ewostatewos established his own monastic community in Sara'e (in present day Eritrea). There, he was joined by many students and taught until about 1337. Among his teachings was the strict observance of Sabbath. When he was opposed by an organized religious rival group of the clergy in Sera'e, he fled the country to Egypt. He faced the same opposition in Cairo by Ethiopian pilgrims.

After Ewostatewos left Ethiopia, the movement was weakned although his followers led by Abba Absad tried their best to maintain its momentum. The movement revived when some of

his followers such as Bekimos, Merkoryewos and Gebre-Iyasus returned home from Armenia. The followers of Ewostatewos soon became active and dispersed to different monasteries in northern Ethiopia. The movement spread to areas like Enfraz, northern Tigray, and Hamessen. The King and the *Abun* opposed the movement. Hence, the anti-Ewostatewos group led by the Abbot of the Hayq Monastery called Aqabe-Se'at Sereqe-Birhan was supported by the Abun and the monarch. The monarch imprisoned some of the Ewostatians owing to the fact that he feared that dispute in the church could divide his kingdom. The clergy expelled Ewostatians from their church services; some of the Ewostatians were forced to withdraw and settle in peripheral areas while some of them sustained their movement in monasteries like Debre- Bizen, Debre-San, etc.

B. Deqie Estifanos/ the Estifanosites

The Estifanosites were a movement within Ethiopian monasticism, called so after their founder and spiritual leader *Abba* Estifanos. The movement rose to prominence in the fifteenth century and continued until the sixteenth century, when it was formally reconciled with the main body of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church.

The head of the movement, *Abba* Estifanos, was born in Agame at the end of the fourteenth century. He established a rigid monastic organization, which emphasized poverty, absolute self-subsistence, equality and autonomy from secular authorities. His adversaries in the monastic circles attempted to discredit him, but the movement gained followers in various monastic communities. When summoned to the royal court, Estifanos was initially able to convince the emperor (probably *Atse* Takla Maryam, r. 1430-33) that he posed no threat to royal power or the unity of the Church. Later, however, he collided with Zara-Yaqob. Estifanos appears to have disapproved of the Emperor's religion initiatives, rejected royal supremacy and authority in spiritual matters and refused to participate in court judiciary procedures. Zara-Yacob took very harsh measures against the Estifanosites allegedly for their opposition of the veneration of St. Mary.

Naod appears to have been more favorably inclined towards the Estifanosites and to have been instrumental in their reintegration into the EOC during the period of Metropolitan *Abune* Yeshaq. For their part, Estifanosites appear to have softened their position; the

excommunication was lifted by the Metropolitan. Despite the importance of the Estifanosites movement for the history of Ethiopia, as yet we have neither a comprehensive critical history of its background and development, nor a clear idea of its real geographical scale, historical significance and influence.

III. The Religious Reforms of Emperor Zara-Yaqob

Emperor Zara-Yaqob (r.1434-68) took several measures to stabilize and consolidate the Orthodox Church. First, he settled the conflict among the Ethiopian clergy in order to create an amicable church-state relationship. In this regard, he made peace with the House of Ewostatewos by reviving Sabbath in the Ethiopian church and the Ewostatian agreed to receive Holy orders from the Ethiopian prelates. Further, he urged the clergy to preach Christianity in remote areas. Besides, he ordered the people to observe fasting on Wednesdays and Fridays and get Father Confessors.

Lack of sufficient religious books was another problem. Thus, the king encouraged the establishment of a library in every church. This was followed by revival of religious literature. He himself wrote some books like *Metsafe-Birhan*, *Metsafe-Me'lad*, *Metsafe-Sillasie*, *Metsafe-te'aqebo Mister*, etc. In addition, during his reign, some parts of *Te'amre-Maryam* were translated from Arabic to Geez.

4.3. Political and Socio-Economic Dynamics in Muslim Sultanates

A number of strong sultanates had emerged since the fourteenth century. Trade was one of the major factors that resulted in the rise and development of those sates. Trade served not only as a major source of livelihood but also acted as a major agent that resulted in the formation of Muslim Sultanates and remained a major source of conflict between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim sultanates. One of the strong Muslim sultanates that emerged along trade routes and became a center of resistance against the Christian Kingdom until the second half of the sixteenth century was the Sultanate of Adal.

4.3.1. The Rise of Adal

After its establishment, Ifat conducted a series of campaigns against its neighbouring sultanates thereby extending its hegemony over these areas. It also resisted the expansion of

the Christian Kingdom. However, one branch of the Walasma family, which realized that Ifat was becoming an easy target to the Christian Kingdom due to its location, moved further to the southeastern lowlands and established new and vigorous Muslim Sultanate of Adal in the highland districts around Harar in 1367. The first center of this extended Walasma Dynasty was at a place called Dakar, a place located to the southeast of Harar. The Walasma family consolidated its power in the new center, and began another phase of military campaigns against the frontiers of the Christian Kingdom. The center of Adal in 1520 changed to the city of Harar and after the defeat of Imam Ahmed; a growing threat from a new force-the Oromo forced the sultanate to change its capital to Awsa in 1576/7, to the present Afar region.

4.3.2. Trade and the Expansion of Islam

Islam spread into the central and southwestern parts of the Ethiopian region through Muslim merchants and preachers. Trade served as channel for the expansion of Islam in the Muslim Sultanates while at the same time it formed the base of the economy of those states. The most known Muslim Sultanates during this period were Ifat (1285-1415) and Adal (1415-1577).

The main trade outlet shifted to Zeila and the old city-states of Mogadishu, Brava, and Merca were used as ports for their hinterland. In the meantime, for the trade in the northeast, Massawa served as an outlet.

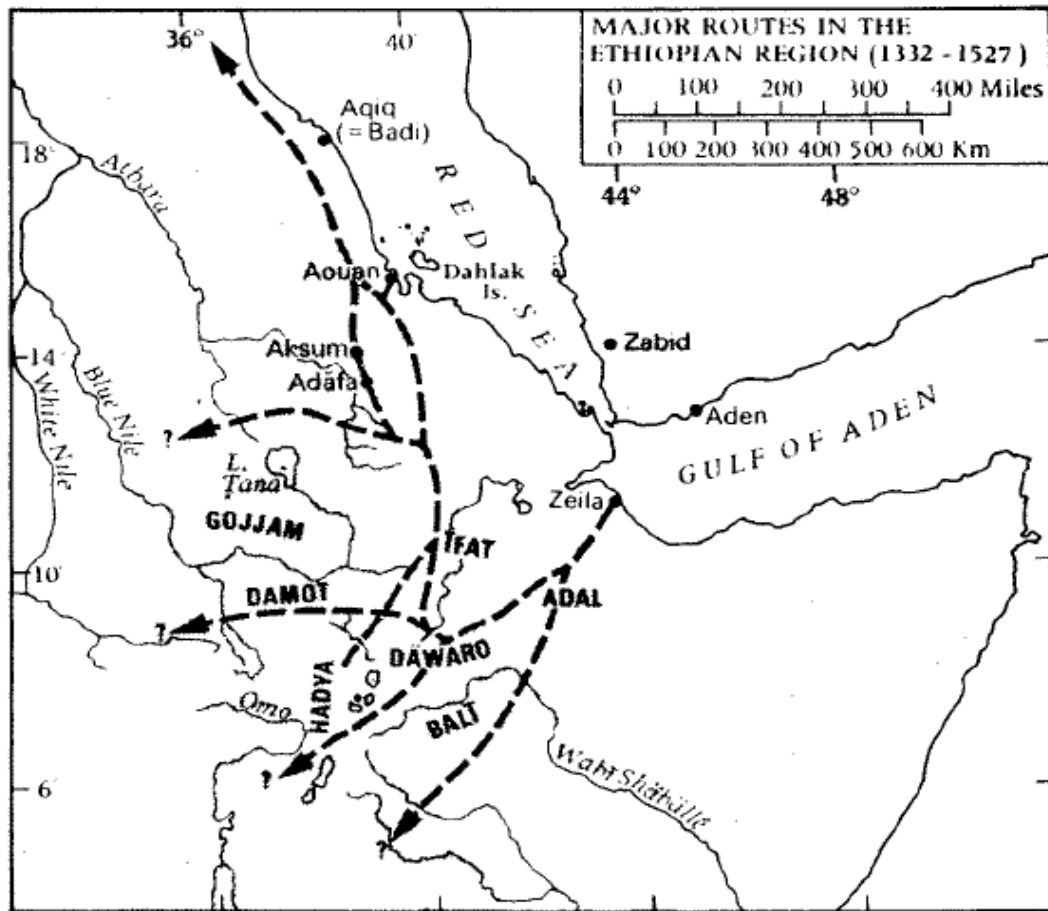
With the revival of trade, different towns and trade centers emerged along the route from Zeila to the interior. Travelers' accounts and chronicles referred to these towns and ruins of mosques and residences mark the existence of market centers, which followed and served the trade coasts. The ruins that mark the landscape around Jigjiga and the highlands of Harar and Charchar attest to the market towns that served the Zeila route. These include Weez-Gebeya in western Shewa/famous market on the Fatagar-Dawaro-Harar route, Suq-Wayzaro in old Damot, Suq-Amaja and the very famous market center Gandabalo on the Ifat-Awsa route. Gandabalo was largely inhabited by Muslim and Christian merchants serving the kings and sultans as agents.

Other big market towns include the ones that linked medieval Amhara with Awsa, called Wasel near what is today Ware-Illu, Qorqora/Qoreta (north of Waldiya) and Mandalay in

southern Tigray. The towns of Dabarwa, the seat of the *Bahre-Negash* (“Lord of the Sea”), and Asmara were the two important entrepôts of caravans in the hinterland of Massawa.

Muslim states had significant control over trade routes that passed through Zeila due to their geographical proximity, although contested by “Solomonic” Kingdom especially after its revival and consolidation.

Map 4: Trade Routes and Muslim Sultanates in Medieval Ethiopia



Source: Bahru Zewde (Compiled), *A Short History of Ethiopia and the Horn*, p. 39.

4.4. Rivalry between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim Sultanates

Zeila was the main outlet to the sea during the medieval period. The ambition to control this trade route and commodities that passed through Zeila led to rivalry between the “Solomonic” rulers and the Sultanate of Ifat. The first recorded conflict between the Christian Kingdom and Ifat took place in 1328 when the Muslim Sultanates organized their

armies to take military action against the Christian Kingdom. The Sultan of Ifat, Haqaddin I stopped merchants belonging to the Christian King, Amde-Tsion, confiscating the goods, capturing, and imprisoning the king's agent, Ti'iyintay returning from Cairo. These actions forced Amde-Tsion to wage a campaign against Haqaddin I; defeated and took him prisoner and eventually replaced him by his brother Sabradin. Both Ifat and Fatagar came under Sabradin.

Ifat was defeated and Sabradin was captured during his retreat. As a result, Ifat, Fatagar and Dawaro were incorporated. Amde-Tsion required from them annual tributes and freedom of movement for all caravans through Zeila. Following the decline of Ifat, other Muslim Sultanates like Sharkha, Bali, Dara, and Arbabani were also seriously weakened.

It was owing to these developments that some members of the Walasma moved their seat of power further east to Adal, from where they continued their struggle. To check their attacks on the highlands, the successors of Emperor Amde-Tsion conducted repeated campaigns into the lowlands. In 1376, Haqadin II came to power and refused to pay tribute and rebelled against Neway-Maryam (r. 1371-80), the son of Amde-Tsion. However, he died fighting in 1386. Similarly, the successor of Haqadin II, Sa'd ad-Din II (c. 1386-1402) gained initial success until king Dawit I (r. 1380-1412) in 1402/3 extended his expansion and defeated him. Sa'd ad-Din II became refuge in Zeila until King Yishaq (r.1413-30) killed him in 1415. Since then the area was called "the land of Sad ad-Din." Following the death of Sa'd ad-Din and loss of Zeila to Christian Kings, the Muslim sultanates declined in power. Sa'd ad-Din's sons who took refuge in Yemen came back to succeed their father. Yet, Adal continued to challenge the Christian state and were successful in killing Tewodros (1412-13) and Yeshaq. This led to intense struggle for predominance.

During the mid-fifteenth century, Emperor Zara Yaqob gained some access to the Red Sea. In 1445, Zara Yaqob defeated Sultan Ahmed Badlay at the battle of Yeguba. As a result, the son and successor of Ahmed Badlay, Mohammed Ahmed (r.1445-71) sent a message of submission to Ba'ede Mariam (r. 1468-78) to remain vassal of the Christian Kings. On the death of Mohammed, however, Adal was still strong and continued its struggle. Hence, the

reigning monarch, Ba'ede-Mariam campaigned against Adal. Despite initial successes, the army of Ba'ede-Mariam lost the battle in 1474.

The successors of Ba'ede-Mariam proved weak in their dealings with the rulers of Muslim Sultanates. At the same time, leaders of the Muslim Sultanate sought to resolve the problem peacefully. As a result, Mohammad ibn Azhar ad-Din (1488-1518) attempted to smoothen relations with the Christian Kingdom. However, among the various Sultans of the Muslim sultanates, Emir Mahfuz carried out some effective military campaigns into the highlands. In 1517 Emir Mahfuz died fighting against Emperor Lebne-Dengel's (r. 1508-40) force and his son-in-law, Imam Ahmed ibn Ibrahim al-Ghazi, popularly known as Ahmed *Grag*n or the "left-handed" took over the leadership.

Apart from the hostile relations, there were wider socio-economic and cultural interactions between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim principalities. As in earlier periods, trade continued to be the major channel of social integration. Also, it had long been the source of friendship, interaction, interdependence, and conflict among the states of the region. The long distance trade and local markets served as core areas of social ties. Relatively, the difference in ecology of the Muslim sultanates and the Christian Kingdom created economic interdependence, which in due course strengthened socio-economic bondage. Merchants of the two regions often moved from the highlands to the coast and vice versa. It was through such caravan merchants that the social links were strengthened and religions spread. These interactions and interdependence in economic, social, cultural and political spheres lay the foundation for modern Ethiopia.

Beside the above discussed socio-cultural and economic interactions, the period witnessed the flourishing of Geez literature as is evident from the works of *Abba* Giorgis Ze-Gasicha and others and philosophies epitomized by Zara-Ya'iqob (not to be confused with the king). On the Muslim side, literature had developed including the works of Arab writers such as Ibn Fadil al Umari, Ibn Khaldun and others.

4.5. External Relations

4.5.1. Relations with Egypt

From the late thirteenth century onwards, the Christian Kingdom continued to maintain relations with Egypt, which was mainly religious in character. In 1272, Yekuno-Amlak sent an emissary to Egypt's Sultan, Baybars, requesting an *Abun* from the Coptic Church. Furthermore, both Egypt and Ethiopia continued to act as protectors of religious minorities in their respective domain. Egypt also wanted to ensure secure flow of the Nile (the Abay River) that originated from Ethiopia.

In the early fourteenth century, Mohammed ibn Qala'un persecuted the Copts and destroyed their churches in Cairo. In response, Amde-Tsion demanded the restoration of the churches and warned that failure to do so would result in the diversion of the Nile waters. Patriarch Marqos (1348- 63) sent a message to Sayfa-Arad (r.1344-71), revealing his imprisonment by the then Egyptian Sultan. Sayfa-Arad is said to have mobilized a huge army against Egypt after which the Sultan released the patriarch and sent a delegation to the King. Besides, Patriarch Matewos (1328-1408) delegated by the Sultan, established harmonious relations between King Dawit and Egypt. The Sultan is said to have sent a piece of the "True Cross" and in return, Dawit is said to have given a number of religious paintings to the Sultan.

In 1437/8, Zara-Yaqob wrote a friendly letter to Sultan Barsbay requesting the protection of Christians in Egypt. Three years later, however, Patriarch Yohannes XI wrote Zara-Yaqob a letter stating the demolition of the famous church of Mitmaq (Debre-Mitmaq). Then Zara-Yaqob sent an envoy to Sultan Jaqmaq (1438-53) with a strongly worded letter. In reply to this message, Jaqmaq sent an envoy to Ethiopia, with complimentary gifts to the King but rejected the reconstruction of the church.

4.5.2. Relations with Christian Europe

As with the Muslim Arab world, the Christian Kingdom maintained relations with Christian Europe. During the medieval period, contacts between the two regions were strongly influenced by the legend of "Prester John". This was followed by sustained relations in subsequent decades. For example, it is stated that Ethiopian delegation was in attendance of

Gian Galeazzo Visconti's coronation in Milan in 1395. In 1418, three Ethiopians attended the Council of Constance. In another report, message from an Ethiopian monarch, Amde-Tsion was presented to King Phillip of France in 1332.

The earliest known message to Ethiopia from a European monarch is the letter of King Henry IV of England dated 1400 A.D. and addressed to "Prester John", the purported king of the Christian Kingdom. The identification of the King with "Prester John" was firmly established in the fourteenth century. They even thought that it was possible to liberate Jerusalem with the help of this King. Hence, during the reign of King Dawit, the leaders of Rome, Constantinople, Syria, Armenia and Egypt sent letters to the king in which they asked for support. King Dawit received some Italian craftsmen consisting mainly of Florentines. In 1402, King Dawit sent his first delegation to Europe led by a Florentine man called Antonio Bartoli.

Alphonso de Paiva V of Aragon received a delegation from Yishaq in the city of Valentia, in 1427. Yishaq's delegation to Europe was to ask for more artisans and military experts. The embassy of the Duke of Berry consisting craftsmen, Neapolitan Pietro, a Spaniard and a Frenchman reached Ethiopia during the reign of Yishaq.

In 1450 a Sicilian Pietro Rombulo, who had been in Ethiopia since the last years of Dawit's reign and who had previously carried out a successful trade mission to India on behalf of the King, was now sent to Europe as Zara-Yaqob's ambassador. An Ethiopian priest, Fikre-Mariam and two other individuals accompanied him. The mission was to Alphonso of Aragon (also ruled as king of Naples and Sicily). King Zara-Yaqob sent delegates to Alphonso to get political, military, and technical assistance. Alphonso wrote a letter to Zara-Yaqob and informed him that he has sent him artisans and masons he requested.

The most authentic pieces of evidence on Ethio-Europe links are the maps of Egyptus Novelo (c. 1454) and Fra Mauro's Mappomondo (1460) which clearly depicted many places and peoples. Venetian Gregorio or Hieronion Bicini visited Ethiopia in 1482. Pedros da Covilhao/Peter de Covilham arrived at the court of Eskindir (1478-1494) in 1493.

The beginning and continued rivalry between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim Sultanates in the fifteenth century strengthened the relation between the Christian Kingdom and Christian Europe. Queen Elleni (the daughter of Hadiya *Garad* and married to King Zara Yaeqob) played an important role in the strengthening of these relations. She had foreseen the threat that came from the Ottoman Turkish who showed a clear interest to support the Muslim Sultanates. She also had foreseen the possibility of consolidating relations with and getting support from Portugal that was against the Turks. In 1508, Portugal sent an envoy to act as an ambassador to Christian Ethiopia. Around 1512, Queen Elleni, the mother and regent of Lebne-Dengel sent an Armenian called Mathew to Portugal. The Portuguese court doubted his authenticity and was received coldly. The Portuguese Embassy led by Rodrigo di Lima, Duwarto Galliba and Francisco Alvarez reached Ethiopia in 1520 and remained for six years. The objective was to establish a naval port against the expanding Turkish power in Red Sea Area. The mission was not successful.

Learning Activities

- What led rulers of the “Solomonic” dynasty to construct a ‘Royal Prison’ at Amba-Gishen?
- Discuss the role and contribution of territorial expansion in shaping today's Ethiopia.
- List some features of the movements of Ewostatewos and Dekike Estifanos.
- Discuss Emperor Zara-Yaqob’s religious reforms?
- Discuss the role played by trade in the spread of Islam in Central, Eastern and Southeastern Ethiopia.
- Describe the circumstances that gave rise to the sultanate of Ifat.
- What was the major source of rivalry between the Christian kingdom and the Muslim Sultanates in medieval and post medieval periods? What role did religion play in the conflict between the two?
- Discuss the nature and contents of Ethiopia’s external relations during this period?

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UNIT FIVE

POLITICS, ECONOMY AND SOCIAL PROCESSES FROM THE EARLY SIXTEENTH TO THE END OF THE EIGHTEENTH CENTURIES (10 hrs)

Introduction

This unit discusses socio-economic and political developments from the early sixteenth to the late eighteenth centuries. These contributed to the making of modern Ethiopia through the intermingling of peoples, economic interdependence and political activities . Major developments of the period include expansion of trade, conflicts between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim Sultanates and foreign interventions; the population movements of the Afar, the Somali, the Argoba and the Oromo; religious expansions, interaction of peoples and the resultant integration across ethnic and religious diversities. Besides, it discusses societies and states in different parts of Ethiopia and the Horn that passed through different historical processes. Finally, this unit discusses the Gondarine Period (1636-1769), *Zemene Mesafint* (1769-1855) including the Yejju rule (1786-1853).

Objectives

At the end of this unit, students will be able to:

- identify the nature of peoples' interaction and major reasons of conflicts between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim Sultanates and consequences;
- analyze the circumstances that led Portuguese and Turkish ' involvement in the region;
- explicate the major population movements and their contributions to the intermingling of peoples in Ethiopia and the Horn;
- identify the political, social and economic developments among peoples and states of Ethiopia and the Horn;
- explain the nature, political developments and major cultural achievement of the Gondarine Period
- discuss political, social and economic conditions during the *Zemene-Mesafint* and Yejju Dynasty.

Unit Starters

- Do you think trade and trade routes can be sources of conflict between states? How? Give examples
- Share orally with your classmates the causes of conflict in a given society
- What do we mean by population movement and why and how does it occur?
- Imagine that your community changes its habitat from one area to another part of Ethiopia and the Horn. What do you think are the likely effects of the movement on the host community and vice versa?
- What do you know about the *Gadaa* system?

5.1. Conflict between the Christian Kingdom and the Sultanate of Adal and After

As discussed in unit four, the revival of long-distance trade caused competition and struggle for control over the trade routes between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim principalities. This was followed by a series of wars, which were depicted as wars for religious supremacy in historical accounts of Christian and Muslim clerics. While mal-administration and exploitation of periphery made military mobilization possible, religion provided ideological justification for the wars. However, the interest to control trade routes lay at the heart of the conflict between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim Sultanates that continued for over two centuries, culminating in the wars between the Christian Kingdom and the Sultanate of Adal that lasted from 1529 to 1543.

As a prelude to this conflict, among the Muslim Sultanates, internal strife, corruption and anarchy was intensified and a new leadership was urgently called for. Such leadership came from Imam Ahmed Ibn Ibrahim al-Ghazi. The origins of Imam Ahmed, alias “the left-handed,” are obscure. He was born at Hubet in between Dire Dawa and Jigjiga and raised by his devout Muslim kin in one of the oases on the route to Zeila. He was a devout Muslim. He soldiered for *Garad* Abun of Adal, who during his few years in power called for Islamic Puritanism.

According to local tradition, the Imam withdrew to the countryside, upon the death of his source of inspiration, *Garad* Abun, and started calling for devotion to the teachings of Islam.

Here came fundamental change in the cause of the confrontations. After Imam Ahmad's rise to power under circumstances discussed above, the battles were not just fought for control of the long-distance trade route going through Zeila but mainly because there was environmental pressure among the Afar and Somali pastoralists pushing to approach Harar and the Christian Kingdom. For centuries, lowland inhabiting Muslim pastoralists had wanted to expand to high plateaus for better and enough pasturelands and attempted to do so but only to be held back by the Christian army. With increased population and overgrazing in Somali and Afar of eastern Ethiopia, between the thirteenth and sixteenth centuries, raiding and counter-raiding at water holes or animal rustling intensified.

It was one of the Imam's remarkable achievements in leadership that he mobilized the pastoral communities of the Afar, the Somali, the Harla, Harari and others to a common cause. He convinced them not to fight amongst themselves but to unite and expand to the Christian Kingdom and resolve their pressing material needs while at the same time guarding Islamic doctrines and practices from the infiltration of any alien religious doctrine. He was able to gain acceptance as Imam and consolidated his army to fight the Christian Kingdom.

Meanwhile, Lebne-Dengel was enthroned when he was only eleven. Assisted by the elderly Elleni and due to internal conflicts in Adal, the Christian state initially retained its interest and even advanced into Muslim territory scoring significant victories in the early sixteenth century. As a result, most of the Muslim Sultanates including Adal were made tributaries to the Christian Kingdom.

However, shortly, Adal fell to Imam Ahmed's army. By the time Imam Ahmed was strong enough for military confrontation in 1520, he refused to pay tribute and this was followed by a campaign against the Christian Kingdom in 1527. The Imam's army fought fiercely and controlled the territories including Bali, Dawaro, Fatagar, Sidama, Hadiya and Kambata and putting the Christian Kingdom at risk.

In 1528, realizing the rising threat, Lebne-Dengel mobilized a vast force from his domain and encamped about fifty kilometers east of what is now Addis Ababa. In addition to logistical problems, the leadership of the army of Christian Kingdom failed to adopt a common strategy to defeat Adal's force. On the other hands, Imam Ahmed's highly

motivated but small-sized army faced no such logistical challenges. The Imam's army had also an excellent leadership characterized by better mobility and flexible tactics with a unified command.

As a result, the larger and well-equipped Christian army was defeated in one of the most decisive engagement at the battle of Shimbira Kure in 1529, near present day Mojo. After the victory, the Imam's army made a large-scale control of the territories of the Christian Kingdom including Shewa, Amhara, Lasta, and moved as far north as Mereb Melash. By 1535, Imam Ahmed's empire stretched from Zeila to Massawa on the coast including the Ethiopian interior. As he penetrated deep into the Christian Kingdom, Imam Ahmed established a civil administrative bureaucracy constituted from his own men and newly recruited personnel from the Christian territories.

One of the most illuminating figures during the war was the wife of the Imam, Bati Del Wanbara. She was the daughter of a Muslim military commander of Adal known as Mahfuz. Tradition claimed that Del Wanbara had encouraged her husband to avenge the death of her father. She accompanied her husband throughout his expeditions and she is said to have marched even in a state of pregnancy during which she was unable to use mules. Indeed, she delivered her two sons during the campaigns of 1531 and 1533 in Ifat and present day Tigray respectively.

On the part of the Christian Kingdom, the military set back forced the reigning king, Lebne-Dengel, to retreat finally dying in 1540 as a fugitive. His son and successor, Gelawdewos (r. 1540-1559), continued to face the wars this time with more intensity as Imam Ahmed had received Turkish musketeers. In the meantime, based on earlier request made by Lebne-Dengel in 1535, about four hundred Portuguese soldiers, armed with matchlocks arrived in the Christian court in 1541. The force was led by Christopher da Gama, the youngest son of Vasco da Gama. However, in August 1542 the Christian army was defeated in Ofla, in today's southern Tigray. In the battle, about two hundred Portuguese were killed and their leader Christopher da Gama was beheaded.

An important anecdote that should be mentioned here is the role of Lebne-Dengel's wife Seblewongel. She is said to have participated in the war against Imam Ahmed in 1542 when the army of the Christian Kingdom lost almost half of the Portuguese soldiers. After the success, Imam Ahmed was confident about his army's ability to repulse any future attack by the force of the Christian Kingdom that he sent his allies back home and let his army camp. On the part of the Christians, preparations were made for final confrontation under the leadership of Emperor Gelawdewos (r.1540-59). The Queen mother, Seble-Wongel, advised the reigning emperor how to prepare and march for the battle of Woyna-Dega. Due to limited resources, the monarch employed hit and run strategy, which severely affected Imam's army. Imam Ahmed's army could not use its previous advantage of easy mobility because they did not know where the attacks came from. On February 25, 1543 while Imam Ahmed was encamped near Lake Tana, he was attacked and killed after a fierce fighting at the battle of Woyna-Dega.

Soon after the battle, Gelawdewos was confident that the nobility and his army were loyal to him. As a result, the king restored possession of almost all the northern and central plateau. Muslim communities in the highlands submitted to Gelawdewos and he was tolerant toward them to promote national conciliation and to develop revival of smooth relations with the Muslim world. Besides, Gelawdewos was able to restore many of the pre-1520s territories and tributary regions. The king attempted to reconsolidate the state through campaigns to different areas and camping *Chewa* (regiment) in border areas. By the early 1550s, Gelawdewos had established a strong Christian Kingdom. However, the control over the Muslim dominated areas was not an easy task. In the period, the growing challenge to the Christian state came from the retreating soldiers of the Sultanate of Adal, the Ottoman Turks, Jesuit interlude, and Oromo advance into the center. Adal under the leadership of Nur Ibn al-Waazir Mujahid was ready to wage war against the Christian state for revenge. In 1559, the forces of Emir Nur confronted Gelawdewos and killed the king himself.

Emperor Minas (r.1559-1563) who succeeded Gelawdewos defeated the Turks' force and reclaimed territories in the coast including Dabarwa. However, in the early 1560s, Yishaq revolted and allied with the Turks against him. Similarly, Sartsa-Dengle (r.1563-1598) had to defend his territory from the Turks while fighting with the Agaw, Gumuz, Bete-Israel,

Sidama, Enarya and the Oromo. The emperor then marched to the north, defeated Turkish forces, and restored the territories.

The Muslim-Christian conflict had resulted in a number of consequences. One of the most obvious was the huge human and material cost. It is also evident that both the Muslim Sultanate and Christian Kingdom were weakened thereby paving the way for an easy infiltration and success of the Oromo population movement. On the positive side, it should be restated that the war had arguably resulted in cultural interaction among the peoples of Ethiopia. Linguistic and religious interactions accompanied by intermarriages among peoples of the various cultural groups were one of these manifestations in the long history of Ethiopia and the Horn.

Competition for supremacy over the Red Sea and the Indian Ocean between Portugal and the Ottoman Turks gave the prolonged conflict between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim principalities a global dimension. Middle Eastern powers including the dominant Ottoman Empire who were the intermediaries of the international trade were adversely affected by the discovery of a new sea route to India by Vasco da Gama in 1498. They tried to counter the Portuguese encroachment into the East, while Portugal for its part began to look toward the Christian Kingdom of Ethiopia as an ally, reviving the old "semi-spiritual quest" for Prester John. From the first decade of the sixteenth century, messengers were sent. However, actual military alliance did not take place because Ethiopia was not a sea power to give a meaningful maritime support to Portugal against the Ottoman Turks. On its part, the Christian Kingdom asked Portugal's military assistance against its Muslim rival.

Having noticed the movement of diplomatic missions between the Christian Kingdom and Portugal, the Turks gave moral and military support to Imam Ahmed. In 1540, the Imam turned to his Muslim ally, Turkey, for assistance and regional Ottoman authorities provided two hundred Muslim musketeers and ten cannons.

5.2. Foreign Intervention and Religious Controversies

As with the state, the church was weakened by the wars against the sultanate of Adal. The destruction of property and deaths of its clergy hampered the operation of the Church and by extension its service as an ideological arm of the state. At the same time, the monarchy could

not count on the traditional political and military apparatus to withstand the continued expansion of the Oromo deep into the Christian Kingdom and then to consolidate the Christian Kingdom. Thus, revival was sought in the church.

The rulers of the Christian Kingdom may have regarded an alliance with Roman Catholicism as a tactic to secure sufficient modern weaponry and training to restore its lost territories. In 1557, several Jesuit missionaries along with their bishop, Andreas de Oviedo, came to Ethiopia to expand Catholicism. The Jesuits promoted Catholic doctrine of two different and therefore separate, natures of Christ-divine and human, which was contrary to Monophysite theology of Ethiopian Orthodox Church. EOC taught that Christ, through union or *Tewahedo* had a perfect human nature inseparable from the divine. The leading members of the mission who played key role in efforts to evangelize the country include Joao Bermudez, Andreas de Oviedo, Pedro Paez and Alfonso Mendez.

The Jesuits began their evangelical effort with Emperor Gelawdewos (r.1540-59), hoping that the rest of the society would follow suit. Gelawdewos listened and engaged in doctrinal debates with the missionaries, but he was not prepared to give in. Instead, he defended the teachings of Orthodox Christianity in a document entitled the *Confession of Faith*. Minas and Sertse-Dengel, who succeeded Gelawdewos one after the other, were too busy fighting against the Oromo and the Turkish forces to engage the Jesuits in their courts. The Jesuits got relative success with Emperor Za-Dengel (r. 1603-4), who was said to have been sympathetic to Catholicism. Yet Za-Dengel's reign was too short for the Jesuits to effect the desired result. Za-Dengel was overthrown by Yaqob (r. 1598-1603; 1604-7), who met a similar fate in the hands of Susenyos (r. 1607-32).

Susenyos who was challenged by provincial leaders who refused to pay tribute, integrated the Oromo with the forces of the central government to consolidate his power and stabilize the country. Probably as a means to this, Susenyos sought for an alliance, which he got through the diplomatic advisory of Pedro Paez. In 1612, Susenyos converted to Catholicism and announced it to be state religion later in 1622. In the meantime, in 1617-8 several anti-Catholic voices mounted following the changes in liturgy and religious practices.

Even worse, with the monarch's consent, another Spanish Jesuit, Afonso Mendez ordered reconsecration of Orthodox priests and deacons and rebaptism of the mass. Besides, he called for the suspension of Old Testament customs such as male circumcision and the observance of the *Sabbath*. Additional pronouncements include prohibition of preaching in Ge'ez, fasting on Wednesdays and Fridays, reverence for Ethiopian saints and the Ark of Covenant (*Tabot*). Meanwhile, he ordered eating pork, Latin Mass and Gregorian calendar to be adopted. The reforms led to revolts led by the ecclesiastics and the nobility. Even loyal followers of the emperor including his own son Fasiledas (r. 1632-67) were opposed to the changes initiated by the Jesuits.

After 1625, controversies, rebellions, repressions mounted and the state came to the verge of falling apart. In a battle in June 1632, large number of peasants lost their lives in one day. Finally, the emperor abdicated the throne in favor of Fasiledas, who reversed the Catholic transformation. Fasiledas restored the position of Orthodox Church as the state religion, expelled the Jesuits and punished local converts including Susenyos' brother and the most fervent supporter of Catholicism, Se'ela Kristos. Fearing another religious conflict, Emperor Fasiledas introduced a "closed-door" policy, which isolated the country from all Europeans for about a century and a half. Conversely, he initiated and adopted a policy of close diplomatic relations with the Islamic world and formed an alliance with the neighboring Muslim states to ensure that no European crossed into the Christian Kingdom. As a result, in 1647, he concluded an agreement with the Ottoman Pasha at Suakin and Massawa to the effect that the latter should block any European from entering in to his territory. By doing so, Fasiledas was able to restore peace and order. Ethiopia's diplomatic break from Europe remained effective until the beginning of the nineteenth century with the exception of secret visits by a French Doctor Charles Jacques Poncet and the Scottish traveler James Bruce in 1700 and 1769, respectively.

Yet, the Jesuit intervention triggered doctrinal divisions and controversy within the Ethiopian Orthodox Church that was divided into disputant sects and reached its peak during the *Zemene Mesafint*. *Tewahedo* teaches *Hulet Lidet* (two births) of Christ: first in eternity as a Divine Being the eternal birth and second, born again from St. Mary into the world as a perfect man and perfect divinity united in one nature, thus *Tewahedo* (United). It was

dominant in Tigray and Lasta. *Qibat* (Unction) was also developed from *Hulet Lidet* doctrine and accepted the eternal birth as the first birth of Christ, but claimed that at the moment of his incarnation, when he was born into the world, Holy Ghost anointed him. This sect was dominant in Gojjam. *Sost Lidet*/Three Births (*Ya Tsega Lij*/Son through Grace) taught that Christ was first born in eternity as divine being, was born again in the womb of St. Mary and anointed by Holy Ghost. This sect was dominant in Gonder and Shawa.

5.3. Population Movements

The movements of people from one place to another have played important roles in shaping the history of Ethiopia and the Horn. population movements occurred in the Horn due to various reasons, in varied scales and followed different directions. People moved from place to place due to pull and push factors, which can be summed up as natural and social. Specifically, people move out from their habitats in search of resources and better living environment in general. In Ethiopia and the Horn, the causes of the movements could be attributed to the region's long socio-political conditions involving military conflicts, drought and demographic factors.

Population movements of the medieval period had extensive effects including the integration of peoples across ethnic and religious lines. Major outcomes of population movements during the period under consideration include religious, ethnic and linguistic interactions and intermingling of peoples. Specifically, this has resulted in intermarriage of peoples, change of abode, original culture and evolution of new identities.

5.3.1. Population Movements of the Argoba, Afar, and Somali

The military conflict between the Christian Kingdom and the Sultanate of Adal in the late fifteenth and the early sixteenth centuries was partly responsible for the population movement of the Argoba, Afar and Somali. In addition, pressure on the environment was a major factor for the population movement. Their territories lay in the region where trade routes passed and hence were affected by the consequences of the military conflict. These peoples moved back and forth in response to the ongoing military conflict.

The Argoba: the Argoba were major agents of Islamic expansion, trade and Muslim state formation in the Horn. For instance, the sultanate of Shewa and Ifat were established by the

Makhzumite and Walasma Dynasties respectively. Towards the end of the thirteenth century, the sultanate of Shewa moved further to the east as the result of the pressure from the Christian Kingdom. The sultanate of Ifat, in which the Argoba were dominant, became the center of Muslim resistance. On the eve of the wars of Imam Ahmed al Ghazi, the Argoba joined the Afar and the Somali against the Christian Kingdom. The area inhabited by the Argoba was also a target of the expanding Christian Kingdom and was the major center of conflict. This was because the major caravan trade routes passed through Argoba territory. As a result, the Christian-Muslim rivalry and the conflicts thereof led to the destruction of sultanates and dispersion of the people. The enduring effect of the conflict can be observed from the fragmented settlement patterns of the people.

The Afar: before the sixteenth century, due to drought, the Afar moved towards the east until they reached the middle Awash. Trade routes linking the ports in the Horn passed through the Afar's territory. As a result, the region was the centre of competition between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim sultanates to control the trade routes. Besides being actors in the conflict, the conflict inevitably pressurized the Afar to move into different directions to avoid the risk of the conflicts. Their pastoral economy helped the Afar to survive the destructive effects of the wars of the sixteenth century..

The Somali: their territory lay in the region traversed by major trade routes during medieval period. Prior to the sixteenth century wars between the Christian Kingdom and the Muslim Sultanates, there was environmental pressure on Somali inhabited areas. The population movement of the Somali was a strong force behind the military strength of the Imam. However, the population movement of the Somali did not last for long as they returned to their home base following the defeat of Imam Ahmed in 1543.

5.3.2. Gadaa System and Oromo Population Movement (1522-1618)

A. The Gadaa System

The Oromo population movement of the sixteenth century cannot be better understood without considering the *Gadaa* system. The *Gadaa* system was an institution through which the Oromo socially organized themselves, administered their affairs, defended their territories, maintained law and order, and managed their economies. This section reflects on

the operation of the *Gadaa* system in relation to the Oromo population movement of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries.

Studies do not clearly indicate when and how the *Gadaa* system emerged. However, it is clear that for long the society organized their politics, economy, social, cultural, and religious affairs through the *Gadaa* institution. The account by Abba Bahrey indicates that during the early sixteenth century, the system fully functioned because of which the Oromo were well organized. Thus, it is reasonable to think that the Oromo had practiced the *Gadaa* system long before the sixteenth century movement.

Recent studies based on the *Gadaa* calendar and *Gadaa* centers suggest that the system evolved from the earlier Cushitic age-set social organization. Time computation and recording history was based on the eight-year segment of time. In the system, eight years represented one *Gadaa* period, 5-*gadaa* periods or 40 years represented one generation and nine generations represented an era. Accordingly, the earliest eras of *Gadaa* but still obscure were those of *Bidiri Dhoqqe*. Prior to the beginning of *Gadaa* Borana-Barentu around 1450 AD, the Oromo passed through known eras of *Taya*, *Tasaa*, *Munyo*, *Suflu*, *Maddile*, *Abroji*, *Dhittacha* and *Warra-Daye* (warden), each of which survived for an era. *Gadaa* was interrupted and revitalized during various eras because of various internal and external factors. For instance, the Borana-Barentu *Gadaa* was instituted after interruption for nearly two generations. It was revived in 1450 at Madda Walabu that became the central *Chaffe* (assembly) and seat of the senior *Qallu* until 1900.

The *Gadaa* system constituted elements of democracy such as periodic succession and power sharing to prevent a one-man rule. Other principles of the system included representation of all lineages, clans and confederacies. It also served as a mechanism of socialization, education, maintenance of peace and order, and social cohesion. In addition, *Gadaa* constituted rules of *arara* (conflict resolution), *guma* (compensation), and *rakoo* (marriage).

The *Gadaa* system organized the Oromo society into age-grades and generation sets delineating members' social, political, and economic responsibilities. In the system, ten age-grades and five classes operated in parallel. The system provided a socio-political framework that institutionalized relationship between seniors and juniors and egalitarian relations among

members of a grade. The system helped the members of age-sets to develop a consistent and stable sense of self and others. Sons joined the first grade as members of *Gadaa* class (generation class or set) forty years after their fathers and were initiated into the next higher grade every eight years. The following table shows a common version of age-grades and roles associated to them.

Table II: Age-grades and their roles

Gadaa-grade	Age	Roles
Dabale	birth-8 years	socialization
Game	9-16	
Folle	17-24	military training, agriculture etc
Qondala	25-32	military service
Raba-Dori	33-40	candidates for political power
Luba	41-48	leaders of <i>Gadaa</i> government
Yuba	49 to 80	senior advisors, educators and ritual leaders

Source: Gada Melba, *Oromiya* (Khartoum, 1988), p. 11.

The *gadaa/luba* assumed power for eight years. The head of the government was known as *Abba-Gadaa* literally “father of the period” who was assisted by several elected representatives from among the generation set. These included *Abba Bokku* (father of scepter), *Abba Chaffe* (head of the assembly), *Abba-Dula* (war leader), *Abba Sera* (father of law), *Abba Alanga* (judge), *Abba Sa'a* (father of treasury) and other councilors.

In the *Gadaa* system, the senior *Qallu* (*Abba Muda*) played indispensable roles in power transfer and legitimizing the ruling *gadaa* class. Women maintained their rights by the *Sinqe* institution, which helped them to form sisterhood and solidarity. Women from childhood to old age i.e. *guduru* (pre-pubescent), *qarre* (adolescent, ready for marriage), *kalale* (wives of *Luba* and *Yuba*) and *cifire* (wives of *Gadamojji*/above 80 years) were believed to have sacred power. They involved in occasions like power transfer, conflict resolution, thanks-giving and others. The *kalale* were also privileged to support and advise the ruling class.

The *Gadaa* system functioned by the cyclical power transfer from one *Gadaa* class to the next every eight years. With some minor differences in nomenclature in different parts of Oromo territories, the five *Gadaa* classes (generation sets) are listed below:

Table III: The Five *Gadaa* Classes

Fathers	Sons
<i>Melba</i>	<i>Harmufa</i>
<i>Mudena</i>	<i>Robale</i>
<i>Kilole</i>	<i>Birmajii</i>
<i>Bifole</i>	<i>Mul'ata</i>
<i>Michille</i>	<i>Dulo</i>

Source: C.F. Beckingham and G.W.B. Huntingford trans. and eds., *Some Records of Ethiopia, 1593-1646* (London: Hakluyt Society, 1954).

B. The Oromo Population Movement (1522-1618)

A combination of natural and manmade factors caused the Oromo population movement of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. Natural factors include demographic pressure and subsequent need for land to accommodate the growing human and livestock population. Furthermore, the conflict between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim Sultanates from the thirteenth to the sixteenth centuries might have pressurized mainly pastoral Oromo groups to leave the lands they inhabited for other areas.

In the early decade of the sixteenth century, when the population movement began, the Oromo were already organized under Borana and Barentu confederacies. The Oromo forces took northern direction and passed through a corridor between Mount Walabu and Lake Abbaya. When they reached half way between Lakes Abbaya and Hawassa, they took westward and penetrated across the Bilatte River to the southwest. Then they headed northwards to the lakes region of the Rift Valley.

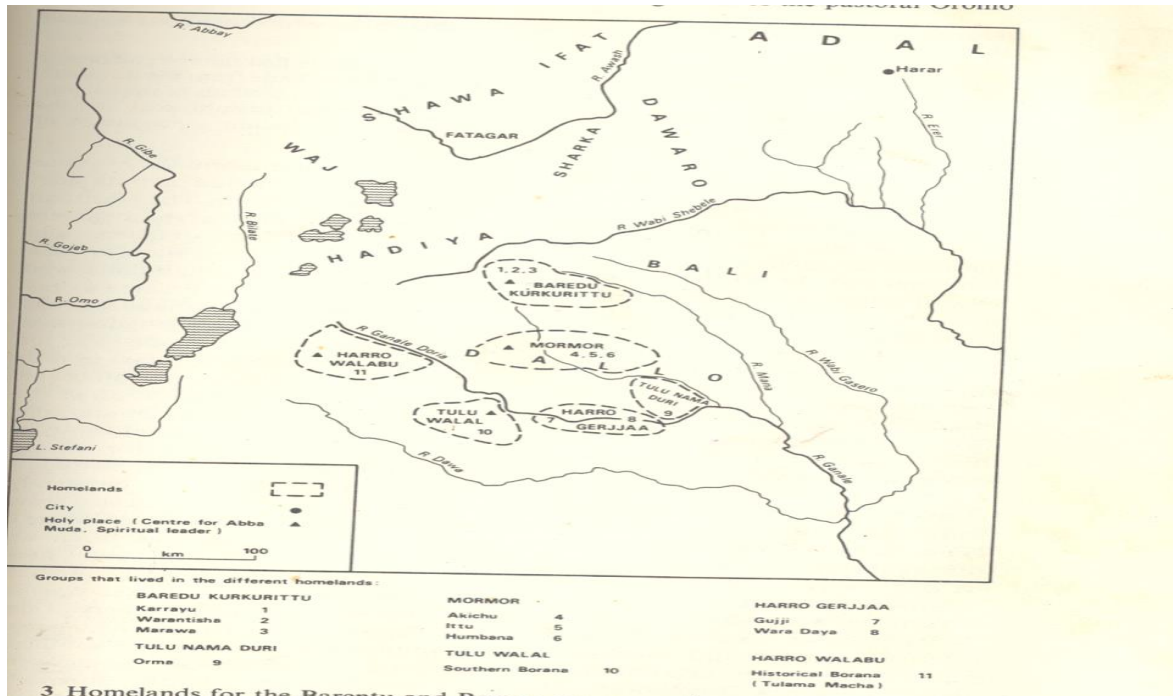
From 1522 to 1618, the Oromo fought twelve *Butta* wars. Accordingly, the first *Gadaa* i.e *Melba* (1522-1530) fought and defeated Christian regiment Batra Amora led by Fasil and occupied Bali while *Mudena* (1530-8) reached the edge of Awash River. The *Kilole* (1538-46) controlled Dawaro after defeating Christian regiment Adal Mabraaq while *Bifole* (1546-54) advanced to Waj and Erer. The *Michille* (1554-62) scored victory over Hamalmal's force at Dago, and Jan Amora forces as well as Adal led by Emir Nur Mujahiddin at Mount Hazalo. The *Harmufa* (1562-70) fought Minas (r.1559-63) at Qacina and Wayyata; occupied Angot, Ganzyi, Sayint etc.

In 1574, Sartsa Dingil's (r.1563-97) cavalry led by *Azzaj* Halibo defeated *Robale gadaa* (1570-78) at Woyna Daga, but Robale recovered by defeating Zara'a Yohannis' force. The *Birmaji* (1578-86) controlled Ar'ine in Waj, crossed Jama to Wolaqa and overwhelmed the Daragoti regiment. The *Mul'ata* (1586-94) seized Damot, Bizamo, Gafat, Dambiya and Tigray.

In the early seventeenth century, the Dulo (1594-1602), *Melba* (1603-10), and *Mudena* (1610-18) expanded to West and Northern parts of the Horn of Africa while others like the Warday moved to Kenya and Bur Haqaba and Majertin in Somalia. In addition to the wars between the Christian Kingdom and Muslim Sultanates, the organization of the Oromo under the *Gadaa* system played crucial role in the success of the Oromo population movement.

In the course of their movement into various regions, different Oromo branches established *Gadaa* centers. Accordingly, *Oda* Nabee of Tulama, *Oda* Roba of Sikko-Mando (Arsi), *Oda* Bultum of Itu-Humabenna, *Oda* Bisil of Mecha and *Oda* Bulluq of Jawwi Mecha became major *Gadaa* centers. Other places, which became *Gadaa* centers, were Gayo of Sabbo-Gona, Me'e Bokko of Guji, *Oda* Dogi of Ilu, *Oda* Hulle of Jimma, *Oda* Garado of Waloo, etc. *Gadaa* leaders such as Dawe Gobbo of Borana, Anna Sorra of Guji, Makko-Bili of Mecha, Babbo Koyye of Jimma and others established *Gadaa* centers and laid down cardinal laws in their respective areas

Map 5: *Gadaa* Centers



Source: Mohammed Hassen, *The Oromo of Ethiopia*, p.15.

However, various Oromo groups kept their relations through the office of *Abba Muda* (the father of anointment) seated at Madda Walabu and formed alliances during times of difficulty. Besides, they obeyed similar *ada* (culture) and *sera* (law) through sending their delegates to Madda-Walabu, the central *chaffe* until the pan-Oromo assembly was forbidden in 1900 due to the political influence of the Ethiopian state.

In due course, *Gadaa* devised effective resource allocation formula including land. Land holding system to regulate resource and their interaction among different clans is known as the *qabiyye* system. The system established rights of precedence (seniority) in possession of land. Accordingly, place names were given the names of pioneers as markers of *qabiyye* rights.

5.4. Interaction and Integration across Ethnic and Religious Diversities

The political, social, and economic processes of the medieval period were the major factors for the people's interactions across regions. Such interactions occurred during peace and conflict times. The cases in point were the trade contacts and conflicts to control trade routes,

religious expansion, and territorial expansion and population movements. One of the major consequences of the interactions in the medieval period particularly in the population movement of the sixteenth century was the integration of peoples across ethnic and religious diversities in Ethiopia and the Horn. Population movement of the period relatively covered extensive geographical areas in the region. It involved diverse ethnic groups, cultures, and religions from south to north and from east to west. It is apparent that territorial and religious expansion by the Christian kingdom diffused Christian tradition from north to the south. Similarly, the wars of Imam Ahmed and the population movements of the Argoba, the Afar and the Somali caused the expansion of Islam into the central parts of Ethiopia.

One consequence of the Oromo population movement was that it put an end to the wars between the Christian and Muslim states as well as the southward expansion of the Christian state. At larger scale, the Oromo contact with diverse peoples in the sixteenth century brought far-reaching integrations among peoples across ethnic and religious background. The Oromo integrated non-Oromo through two adoption mechanisms: *Guddifacha* and *Moggasa*. *Guddifacha* refers to the adoption of a child by a foster parent. In this system, the child enjoyed equal rights and privileges with a biological child. Likewise, *Moggasa* was a system of adopting non-Oromos commonly known as *Oromsu*. *Moggasa* was the practice of incorporation of individuals or groups to a clan through oath of allegiance with all the rights and obligations that such membership entailed. *Moggasa* was undertaken by the Abba Gadaa on behalf of the clan. The adopted groups gained both protection and material benefits. The process significantly contributed to the social cohesions, national integration, and the revival of long-distance trade.

The interactions also resulted in an exchange of socio-cultural values and institutions. A number of peoples in the neighborhood of the Oromo adopted *Gadaa* system and Oromo language. Likewise, the Oromo adopted and adapted cultures and traditions of the people with whom they came into contact. The case in point is the adoption of monarchical systems and the integration of the Oromo to the Christian and Muslim cultures. It is important to mention the rise of nobles in the northern Oromo in politics particularly during the Gondar period, *Zemene-Mesafint* and the making of modern Ethiopia.

5.5. Peoples and States in Eastern, Central, Southern and Western Regions

It is not possible in the space of a brief teaching module such as this to provide an exhaustive detail of societies and states in eastern, central, southern, and western parts of the country in the period covered by this unit. Thus, this section explores the history of some of the states (as illustrations) in the period under consideration. Although there was no one criterion used to select the states, due regard has been given to balance the number of states selected from each region mentioned above. The selection of states for discussion also considered availability of sources and treatment in earlier sections.

5.5.1. Peoples and States in the East

Somali

The Somali people inhabited vast territory in the Horn. For long, the Somali practiced pastoral economy and moved between places for centuries possibly in search of sufficient pasture. Ibn Said (1214-86), an Arab geographer, noted that Merca town located in the southern Somali coast near Shabele River was a capital that brought large number of Somalis together during the thirteenth century. The songs celebrating King Yeshaq's (r. 1413-30) military success depicts that the Somali lived close to the Christian Kingdom. Somali contingents also played important role in the victories of the Sultanate of Adal against the Christian kingdom.

Historically, a council known as *shir* governed the society. The decision making process was highly democratic in which all-adult male were allowed equal access and participation. These councils at sub-clan, clan and inter-clan level provided a governing structure that acted as an enforcement of law and justice. The council governed wide-ranging affairs including resource allocation, marriage, trade and crime. As a component of *shir*, the *guurti* (a council of elders) was the highest political council mandated with resolving conflict and crisis.

Afar

The Afar predominantly lived in northeastern Ethiopia and in northern Djibouti, although some have also inhabited southern part of Eritrea. The Afar had an indigenous governance system known as *Makabanto*, which has some elements of democracy. The Afar people were

first mentioned by Ibn Said. During the thirteenth century, they occupied the lowland territory near Bab el-Mandeb.

The land inhabited by the Afars was home for many historical cities such as Maduna and Abasa. Following the collapse of the power of Sultanate of Adal in the sixteenth century, the Afar established their sultanates like Awsa, Girrifo, Tadjourah, Rahaito and Gobad. Awsa Sultanate succeeded the earlier Imamate of Awsa in the middle Awash. The latter polity had come into existence in 1577, when Mohammed Jasa moved his capital from Harar to Awsa. At some point after 1672, Awsa declined and temporarily ended in conjunction with Imam Umar Din bin Adam's recorded ascension to the throne. The Sultanate was subsequently re-established by Kedafo around 1734, and was thereafter ruled by his Mudaito Dynasty. Primary symbol of the Sultan was silver baton. Awsa's economy mainly depended on Bati-Ginda'e trade route. Later it became center of Islamic learning led by preachers like Tola Hanfire.

Argoba

Early reference to the people of Argoba is insufficient. There are two versions on the origin of the people of Argoba. The first version holds that they descended from the followers of the Prophet Mohammed who came to the Horn of Africa and settled at Ifat. The second version claims that the origin of the Argoba is not related with Muslim-Arab immigrants. More plausibly, the Argoba are one of the ancient peoples in the region that accepted Islam very early from religious leaders who came from Arabia.

The Emirate of Harar

Harar is one of the earliest Muslim centers in the region of Ethiopia and the Horn. In the sixteenth century, Harar became the capital of Walasma of Adal replacing Dakar until 1577 when it was shifted to Awsa due to the pressure from the Oromo. Imam Ahmed ibn Ibrahim used Harar as a center from where he launched his campaigns into the Christian kingdom in 1527. Later during the reign of Emir Nur Mujahid, Harar became a walled city where the sultanate of the Harari developed.

In the mid seventeenth century, Emir Ali ibn Da'ud (r. 1647-62) in cooperation with the Oromo established a dynasty which was to rule for nearly two centuries and a half. It was

strengthened by Amirs like Abdul Shakur (1783-94). The Amir's council, *Majilis* engaged in supervising Mosque land, *Waqf* and offering other assistance to the Amir. The emirate grew in importance to be a steady center of Islamic culture and power. Its economic power grew as it controlled trade routes from the Gulf of Aden ports of Zeila and Berbera. Its authority was established over the surrounding Oromo and Somali through trade, inter-marriage, and expansion of Islamic teachings. Egyptians were attracted by such a prominence that they sent an expeditionary force in 1875 and controlled the emirate for nearly a decade. Although it was later restored, and ruled by Amir Abdulahi, as the last emir of the Sultanate for two years, Emperor Menilek's expansion to the region shortly followed in 1887.

5.5.2. Peoples and States in Central and South Central Parts

The Kingdom of Shewa

The Kingdom of Shewa was formed by a Menz ruler Negasi Kristos (r.1696-1703) and eventually controlled districts like Asandabo, Debdabo, Mafud and Yifat. The second king was *Merid Azmatch* Sebestie/Sebastyanos (r.1703-18). Abuye/ Abiyye (1718-45) made Haramba, his capital and tried to subjugate the surrounding Oromo before he was killed by the Karrayu Oromo. In addition to his unsuccessful attempts to control the Afar and Abitchu Oromo, Amaha Iyesus/ Amayyes (r.1745-75) declared authority over Bulga, Efrata, Menz and Tegulet with his capital at Doqaqit which later shifted to Ankober. Asfa-Wosen (r.1775-1808) conquered Antsokia, Asbo, Gedom, Gishe, Merhabete, Morat and Shewa Meda. The dynasty became very strong under *Negus* Sahle-Sellase (r.1813-47), the grandfather of Emperor Menilek II. During his reign, many travelers visited Shewa and he even signed "treaty of friendship and commerce" with the British in 1841.

Shewa's economy was mainly based on agriculture supplemented by trade and craft. Near the capital, Ankobar, there was an important trade center in Aleyu Amba administered by the Shewan court.

Gurage

The Gurage are divided into the Western and Northern Gurage. The first are also known as Sebat Bet Gurage and include: Chaha, Muher, Ezha, Gumer (Inamor, Enner, Endegegna and

Gyeto). The latter are variously known as Kistane, Aymallal or Soddo Gurage. Additional groups included Dobbi, Gadabano and Masqan. The staple crop in Gurage land is *enset*.

The Gurage had traditional system of governance developed over the centuries. It is known as the Yajoka Qicha among the Sebat Bet and the Gordanna Sera among the Kistane. There was, however, no centralized leadership. Power was vested in clan or lineage groups. The descent groups displayed corporate rights, obligations, and influence.

Kambata

By about 1550-70, four communities of separate origin coalesced to form the contemporary state of Kambata which means, “this is the place” (where we live-as the Kambata believe in). The first one, Kambata in the narrow sense, had its original homeland around Mount Hambericho in the heartland of Kambata territory. The other three namely the Dubamo, Donga and Tembaro trace their homeland from Sidama highlands.

If the above processes led to the formation of the nucleus of the state, the ethno-genesis of Kambata also benefitted from Omotic and Semitic peoples who moved into the region at different times. Emperor Yeshak (r.1413-30) annexed Kambata proper and controlled the area between Omo and Bilate Rivers, which he incorporated into the Christian Ethiopian Empire. In 1532, the region was captured by Imam Ahmed’s army, which furthered the interaction of peoples. At the end of the sixteenth century, the groups were recognized as and conscious of the name Kambata related to one of the seven dominant clans (Kambata Lamala) in the region. The people were *ensete* farmers sharing similar culture and speaking the same language called Kambatissa, which belongs to the Highland East Cushitic family together with Qabena, Halaba, Hadiya, Sidama, Gedeo and Burji groups.

The Kambata had a traditional administrative institution called the Hambericho Council. The council had seven members each representing the seven clans in the region. With a king at the top, the council ruled Kambata until the late nineteenth century.

Hadiya

The origin of the state of Hadiya goes back to the thirteenth century. It was mentioned in the Kebra-Negest (*Glory of the Kings*) and it referred to the area west of the Islamic states in the

federation of Zeila. The people were heterogeneous both linguistically and culturally. Semitic-speaking agricultural people dominated north of the state while the southern part was largely inhabited by Cushitic-speaking pastoral communities. There was a considerable Muslim population. By about 1332, the ruler of the Christian kingdom, Amde-Tsion, subjugated Hadiya after defeating its ruler, Amano who supported by a Muslim “prophet” Bel’am aligned with the then leader of Ifat, Sabraddin to confront the Christian force.

From the thirteenth to the sixteenth centuries, Hadiya’s political importance was considerable with sizable population and vast territory. In 1445, a Hadiya king called Mahiqo rebelled against Emperor Zara-Yaqob (r.1434-68) and was consequently replaced by his uncle Bamo. To stabilize the situation, Zara-Yaqob made a political marriage. Accordingly, Princess Elleni, from Hadiya, who became an important historical figure, married Emperor Zara-Yaqob. Another Hadiya leader, Garad Aze refused to pay tribute to Emperor Sartsa-Dengel (r.1563-98), but was suppressed in 1568/9.

The relations between Hadiya and the Christian Kingdom was interrupted following the wars between the latter and Adal and the Oromo population movement until Hadiya's incorporation into the Imperial state in the late nineteenth century. After these two major historical events especially the latter, Hadiya’s population became more diverse. However, descendants of the old Hadiya can be traced from four different linguistic clusters: the Oromo, the Sidama, the Kabena and Alaba, and the Hadiya proper with its sub-groups-the Mareko, Lemu, Soro, Shashogo and Badowacho. As with the Kambata and Sidama, the Hadiya language belongs to the Highland East Cushitic family and their languages are intelligible to members of these ethnic groups.

5.5.3. Peoples and States in the South

Sidama

Historically, the Sidama have been living in the southern parts of Ethiopia occupying lowlands of about 1500 m a.s.l in the Great East Africa Rift Valley that cut through Lakes Hawasa and Abaya up to 3000 m a.s.l in the eastern Sidama highlands of Arbegona, Bansa and Arroressa districts. Agriculture, although practiced traditionally, remained the basis of

Sidama's economy. *Enset* and coffee are Sidama's important food and cash crops respectively.

The Sidama had an indigenous system of governance led by the *Mote* (king). The *Mote* exercised political and administrative authority in consultation with the council of elders called *Songo*. *Songo* members raised any agenda for discussion within the council and submitted their decisions to the *Mote* for approval. Although there was no written constitution, rules were known by heart through generations and practiced accordingly.

The cultural and ritual leader in Sidama society was the *Woma*. He was selected for his ability as a peacemaker, bodily perfection, oratorical ability, wisdom and caution. The *Woma* could not participate in war or cattle raiding as he was considered a man of peace. The *Woma* handled cultural matters such as offering sacrifices to the spirits. He also performed other rituals such as circumcision and marriage.

Sidama society was divided into generation-sets called *Luwa*. The system had five grades each lasting for eight years. These are *Darara*, *Fullassa*, *Hirbora*, *Wawassa* and *Mogissa*. Candidates for *Luwa* received a five-month military training and war songs like *gerarsha* under the leadership of the *gaden* with his deputy called *Ja'law*. The *gaden* settled disputes within his *Luwa*, besides handling the defense of Sidama society together with the *Mote*.

Another important institution of Sidama society is *Seera*. *Seera* was the social constitution of the Sidama people governing social life based on the Sidama moral code, *halale* (the ultimate truth) to judge the right and wrong. Although it was not written and defined with strict enforcement mechanisms, people abide by the rules of *halale* to avoid curse or ostracization by the society.

Gedeo

Contradictory traditions exist regarding the origin of the Gedeo people. The dominant tradition relates the ancestors of the Gedeo to Daraso, who was the older brother of Gujo (father of Guji Oromo). Accordingly, the seven major Gedeo clans descended from the seven sons of Daraso. The clans were grouped in two houses, the first being the *shole batte* (senior house) where the first four clans belonged including more than 25 sub-clans and the second

called *sase batte* (junior house) where the last three belonged having 10 sub-clans. Each clan was exogamous and was assigned for particular duty such as ritual, traditional medicine or leadership.

The Gedeo had a culture called *baalle*, a traditional governance system that worked with age classes and ranking. The *baalle* had seven grades with a 10-year period each creating a 70-year cycle. *Sasserogo* was a federation of three territories; Sobbho, Ributa and Rikuta sharing one *Abba Gadaa* who leaves office every eight years to be replaced by a new holder with the next age set at *baalle* ceremony. It was at this ceremony that all positions ranging from the top, *Abba Gada* down to *Hayitcha* were assumed. Like the neighboring Sidama, with whom they shared a very close language, their economy was based on the cultivation of *enset*.

Konso

The name Konso is invariably used to refer one of the ancient peoples in Ethiopia and the Horn who spoke *affa Konso* (Konso language) and their land. The literal meaning of the term is a “heavily forested hill/ area.” A century ago the highlands of Konso, which was covered by dense forest, had been the traditional home of Konso people while the low-lying environment along Sagan and Woyito river valley served as hunting grounds. Konso attracted the attention of local and international researchers interested in human evolution, as it is one of the earliest human settlement sites in the world.

Agriculture was and remains to be the major economic activity of the Konso. Farmers practiced a fairly balanced and integrated system of specialized agricultural technology. The location of mainland Konso within mosquito infested hot and dry lowlands at the edge of the Great East African Rift Valley led farmers to adopt intensive agriculture. Farmers combined crop production with cattle breeding. At the same time, they adopted soil conservation techniques notably the construction of terraces, which proved helpful to convert rugged and hilly areas into permanent cultivation. Farmers were also adept at selecting plant varieties that withstood harsh climatic conditions. Such complex agricultural practices enabled farmers to produce sufficient food on small plot of land for their sustenance. Besides agriculture, Konso’s economy depended on bee keeping and craftworks. All of these activities attest the ingenuity of local adaptation strategies.

Until the late nineteenth century, the Konso people lived in walled villages (*paletas*) which were further divided into wards called *Kanta*. There was no central authority who acted as sovereign power over the three regions. Each village was ruled by a council of elders called *hayyota* who were selected through direct participation of male members of the village. Membership to the council was not hereditary but rotated every eighteen years.

At the core of the socio-political organization of the Konso appear to be the clan or lineage group and generation set, *Tselta*. The Konso were divided into nine exogamous clans namely Toqmaleta, Elayta, Saudata, Pasanta, Kertita, Ishalayta, Mahaleta, Tikisayta and Argamyta. The *Tselta* had fixed cycle of years starting from birth, although they varied across villages- eighteen in Karat, nine in Takati and five in Turo. The major function of the generation set was informing the responsibilities expected of each age group.

5.5.4. Peoples and States in Southwestern Part

Wolayta

The name Wolayta denotes a specific ethnic group in southwestern Ethiopia and their powerful kingdom, which first emerged as a state in the thirteenth century. According to local traditions, before the emergence of Wolayta as a political unit, the area was inhabited by different communities such as the Badia, Badiagadala and Aruja. The state flourished in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries because of successful wars that the Wolayta fought against their neighbors and the material, human and territorial gains thereof. At the apex of the social and political hierarchy was the *Kawo* (king), assisted by a council of advisors. From the thirteenth to the late nineteenth centuries, two successive dynasties ruled Wolayta: the Wolayta-Malla and the Tigre. Founded in the thirteenth century by Motalami, the Wolayta-Malla seems to have ruled until the end of the fifteenth century. It was then superseded by the Tigre dynasty, so called because it was supposedly founded by Tigreans from northern Ethiopia.

The land of Wolayta is known for its fertility and moderate climate, with green vegetation cover for the most part of the year. All land was nominally owned by the king who granted it to his dependents. In practice, land relationships were ordered according to three basic principles of social organization i.e. kinship, polity and social status. Accordingly, rights over

land were vested in the lineage group, the crown (royal estate) and the nobility. There were also communal lands allocated for grazing and social gatherings to which all members of the society except artisans had equal access. The king rewarded people with land on grounds of gallant deeds in battle and other important contributions to the state. By grants of land or by threats of dispossession the reigning monarch ensured loyalty to the state. Except those who worked on the royal estate, landholders paid tribute to the king. The dominant food crop was *enset* (*Enset Ventricosum*).

Kafa

According to traditions, this powerful kingdom emerged in the fourteenth century. Around mid seventeenth century, the state had come to prominence. The ruling Minjo dynasty and the medieval kingdom of Ennarya had close contact. The Oromo expansion might have forced the ruling house of Ennarya to flee south of the Gojeb which as a result brought Christianity and the royal title *tato* to Kafa.

As with a number of Cushitic and some Semitic peoples of the south, Kafa's economy was based on the cultivation of *enset* on peasant farms supported by trade. Besides working on their land, peasants rendered free labor service and tilled royal estates with the support of slaves who were acquired through raiding or trading, or as payment for debt. As far as trade is concerned, a prosperous commerce took place with Oromo states of the Gibe region. Major trade items, such as musk, coffee, slaves, Ivory, gold, honey-wax, and civet were exported via markets like Tonkolla, Tiffa, Qeya etc.

From the seventeenth to the eighteenth centuries, the kingdom expanded to Bonesho, Mashengo, Maji, Nao, She and Chara. At the apex of the administration of the kingdom was the *Tato* with his major political center at Bonga. Another seat of power was Andarcha, seven miles to southeast. The *Tato* was assisted by a council of seven advisors called *Mikrecho*. The *Mikrecho* served to moderate the power of the king but they played important roles in succession as well.

The Kafa had a tradition of digging deep trenches called Kuripo as defensive barrier. The Gojeb also served as natural protection against external invasion and it might have contributed to their relative independence until 1897.

Yem

The Yem state was located along the eastern banks of the Gibe or to the northeast of the Kafa kingdom. Yem's economy combined agriculture, trade and crafts. Initially, an indigenous dynasty called Dida or Halmam-Gamma ruled Yem from its palace in Dudarkema/Zimarma near Oya, in the vicinity of Bor Ama Mountain. Besides being at the top of the political ladder, the Amno (king) of Yem acted as a chief priest with attributes of divinity. A state council of 12 members named *Astessor* with its chairperson *Waso* assisted the *Amno* in administering the state. *Erasho* were the provincial governors and they were responsible for digging ditches called *bero* and erecting nearly fifty-meter wooden or iron pillars at the center of the kingdom around Brisi Bitu so that the war father, the *Nomiaw*, could patrol the surroundings. Special messengers, *Wosi* carried orders from *Amno* down to district chiefs, *Gagna* and vice versa. In the fourteenth century, the last King Oyokam/Amo Dasha was overthrown by people from the north who founded a new dynasty called *Mowa (Howa)* with its center at Angari. In the nineteenth century, the neighboring state of Jimma Abba Jifar tried to control the Yem which itself was absorbed into the imperial state of Ethiopia under Emperor Menilek II towards the end of the century.

Gamo

Historically, the Gamo inhabited areas from Lakes Chamo and Abaya to the Gughe Mountain and beyond. Gamo's physical landscape can be divided into two: the *geze* (highland) and the *bazo* (lowland). The highlands were densely populated while people who escaped coercion by the state at the political center largely settled the lowlands which also served as hunting fields. A set of interrelated indigenous laws called the *Woga* defined land-use in the Gamo highlands. The laws had their origin in a belief that everything was connected and bound in a delicate balance. Together they formed a natural resource management system that governed everything from interpersonal relationships to the conservation and preservation of pasture, forest, soil, and water.

The cultivation of *enset* had been central to the subsistence of Gamo highlands while maize and sweet potato were staple food crops in the lowlands. Other crops grown in the highlands included barely, wheat, *teff*, peas, beans and cabbage. Besides farming, most farmers kept

cattle for food, farming and manure, which they needed for successful agriculture. Craft making, pot making, tanning and metalworking were other modes of the subsistence system. These people had developed their own indigenous knowledge and technologies in manufacturing different types of tools and weapons, traditional musical and funeral instruments, weaving colorful textiles etc.

The first mention of the Gamo in written records dates back to the fifteenth century in the praise songs of king Yishak (r.1413-30). The song mentioned the Gamo as one of the tributary states to the monarch. The Gamo maintained relative autonomy from control by the Christian Kingdom after war with the Muslim sultanates weakened the latter. Between the sixteenth and the nineteenth centuries, the Gamo lived in scattered settlements and organized in different communities called *dere*. The *dere* were politically autonomous villages (units) but shared three essential features. These were: 1) each *dere* had *kawo* (hereditary ruler) who also offered sacrifices and symbolized the unity of the people. 2) every *dere* had its own initiates called *halaqa* and; (3) every *dere* had its own assembly place called *dubusha*, where communal matters were discussed and disputes solved.

Access to politico-ritual status among the Gamo people was made possible through initiation or election and *baira*, a system of seniority. The two systems functioned both in opposition to each other as well as complementarily. Through initiation or election the *dulata* (assembly) elected married men to positions that were known by different names from one *dere* to another. In some *dere* it was called *halaqa*, in others it was known by the name *huduga* or *maga*. Election to this office was open to all married men and accorded representatives with provisional political authority. The *dulata* had an institutional authority to give decisions on different social, political and many other important matters. The assembly had also the power to impose sanctions as penalty on individuals or groups who committed serious crimes or violated the community's social regulations and cultural values.

The second system, the *baira*, was ascribed and largely based on genealogical seniority according to primogeniture. The Gamo people were distributed in agnatic clans each having a system of individual genealogical hierarchy. The *baira* (senior) of the clan had a privilege over lineage members. The *baira* made animal sacrifice on behalf of their juniors at all levels

of the community. The senior sacrificer of the *dere* is the *kawo*. The concept of *kawo* refers to the first rank status, with variable attributes and he was legitimized by birth and primogeniture. The *kawo* represented the unity of *dere* and played an important role in relations with the outside world.

Dawuro

Dawuro's topography mostly is mountainous and plateau at the central, and lowland and plain at Gojeb and Omo river basins. The land is divided into three climatic zones. These are *geziya* (highland), *dashuwa* (mid-altitude) and *gad'a* (lowland). Such climatic conditions enriched Dawuro with a variety of tree species and natural vegetation/forest. The livelihood of Dawuro people is based on mixed agricultural activities. The language of Dawuro people is Dawurotsuwa, a sub-group of the Omotic family.

Historically, Dawuro land had been inhabited by three major clans namely *Malla*, *Dogolla*, and *Amara* which altogether were regarded as *Gok'as* or *K'omos*. The area was also home for people that came from neighboring Omotic states such as Wolayta, Kucha, Gamo, Gofa, and Kafa and from places like Gondar, Gojjam, Tigray and Shewa. A political alliance through royal marriages was one important factor that facilitated the movement of people from neighboring territories into Dawuro.

By about 1700, the *Kawuka* dynasty had created a big state from a great number of petty chieftainships on the territory between the Gojeb and Omo rivers in the north, east and south and the Kafa high mountains in the west. Among the rulers of the *Kawuka* dynasty of Dawuro, Kati Irashu and Kati Halala were famous. Kati Halala was the grandson of the king of Kafa. During his reign, Dawuro incorporated Konta. He is known for his stone fortifications, which he oversaw to defend his territories from outsiders.

Ari

The Omo River basin had been home to different groups of people since early times. These included the Ari, Dasenech, Tsemayi, Erbo, Hamar, Surma, Meniet, Nyangatom, Bodi, Male, etc. Major economic activities in the region were sedentary agriculture, pastoralism and handcrafts.

The language of the Ari people is called *Araf*, which is one branch of the Omotic language family. The people were sedentary agriculturalist. The society was organized into ten independent clan based chiefdoms. Hereditary clan chief known as *Babi* headed each of these chiefdoms. The clan chief was entitled with both political and ritual authorities over the people of his respective domain. The clan chief was assisted by officially appointed prominent figures in the administration of the political unit. The assistants included *Godimis* (religious leaders), *Zis* (village heads) and *Tsoikis* (intelligence agents of *Babi*).

5.5.5. Peoples and States in the West

Berta and Gumuz

The Berta people inhabit the present Beni-Shangul Regional State. The earliest record of Berta settlement in this region dates from the sixteenth century. The Berta people speak the Berta language as their mother tongue. It is a tonal language classified as a branch of the Nilo-Saharan linguistic group. In addition to the Berta, the Beni-Shangul is home for the Gumuz. They are mentioned by the Scottish explorer James Bruce. He notes that they hunted with bows and arrows, a custom that survives today. The Gumuz speak the Gumuz language, which belongs to the Nilo-Saharan family. It is subdivided in several dialects. Islamic influence had been strong on the Berta and other Nilotes because of their trade and social contacts with the northern Sudan.

Anywa

Historically, the Anywa predominantly inhabited areas along Pibor, Sobat, Gila, Akobo, Agwei, Oboth, Baro, and Alwero Rivers on the western borderlands of the present-day Gambella region. The people speak Dha-anywaa, a sub-branch of the Nilo-Saharan language family. The Anywa had an indigenous administrative system whereby each village lived under a chief called Kuaari who along with the nobles, Nyiye, managed the distribution of farm and grazing fields, settled disputes etc with the community. Although local traditions mention a certain person by the name Oshoda as the founding father of the Anywa, the administration of the territory was not centralized. Economically, they are engaged in small-scale cultivation, fishing and hunting. While most Anywa practiced Christianity, they also believed in traditional religion.

Nuer

Historically, the Nuer lived in areas that extended across the savannas and marshes of the Bahr el-Ghazal and the Upper Nile regions of the Sudan. Since the nineteenth century, they had been largely settled in the plains of Gambella along the Sobat and Baro Rivers and parts of the Sudan. The mainstay of Nuer's economy was cattle breeding supplemented by crop production. The Nuer had developed a rather complex spiritual culture around their cattle, which were used as bride wealth as well. The Nuer had an age-set system combining social and political functions. Nuer boys had to pass through a rigorous test and a series of rites connected with it before they were initiated into adulthood.

Majang

The Majang formed the southern end of the Nilo-Saharan settlement that covered the escarpment of the Oromo inhabited highlands to the Baro plains. Linguistic evidence relates the origin of the Majang to the Boma plateau in South Sudan. Gradually, they moved northwards and settled in forested areas of western Ethiopia. By mid twentieth century, their settlement extended to areas near Dembi-Dollo in the north. Economically, the Majang practiced shifting cultivation and animal husbandry. Other economic activities of the Majang include beekeeping, hunting and fishing.

The Kunama

The Kunama people also called the Baza are one of the ancient inhabitants of western Eritrea on the Gash and Tekkeze Rivers and in today's northwestern and western Tigray. The Arab traveller al-Ya'qubi in 872 A.D. mentions the kingdom of Baza, which is a self-designation of the Kunama.

The Kunama had a customary institution called *sanga-anene* mandated with the administration of the society. Other responsibilities of the *sanga-anene* included granting asylum to new comers in the sanctuary of their compounds and performing rituals as part of reconciliation process in case of homicides. The office of the *sanga-anene* was held by male members of the society. The office was transmitted hereditarily from the eldest brother to the next born through matrilineal line.

The mainstay of Kunama's economy is mixed agriculture. Agriculture is based on the use of hoe, spades, sickles and the ox (camel)-drawn plough. Signs of past practices of terraced agriculture are still visible in some areas of the Kunama. The staple crop among the Kunama is sorghum (*kina*), which also has a ceremonial value. Other crops grown are millet (*bortaor beca*), pulses and maize (*afokina*). The Kunama also keep livestock mainly goats, sheep, oxen, and camels.

5.6. The Gondarine Period and Zemene-Mesafint

5.6.1. The Gondarine Period

A. Political Developments

The period of Gondar began from the reign of Emperor Sartsa-Dengle when the political center of Ethiopian emperors shifted to Gondar area. Emperor Sartsa-Dengle established royal camp at Enfranz in 1571. Emperor Susenyos also tried to establish his capital near Gondar in such places as Qoga, Gorgora, Danqaz and Azazo. Gondar was founded in 1636 when Fasiledas established his political seat there.

Gondar achieved its glory during the reigns of its first three successive emperors: Fasiledas (r.1632–67), Yohannes I (r.1667-82) and Iyasu I (r.1682- 1706). Among the major reforms during these periods were the restoration of Orthodox Church as state religion, and the establishment of a royal prison at Amba Wahnii to solve problems stemming from power rivalry. Emperor Yohannes I and his council established a separate quarter for Muslims at Addis Alem. His successor, Iyasu I, reformed land tenure system, introduced a system of land measurement in Begemder, taxes, and customs, and revised the *Fetha Negest* (the civil code).

The assassination of Iyasu the Great by a faction under the leadership of his own son, Tekle-Haymanot, ushered in political instability in Gondar involving intrigues and poisoning of reigning monarchs. Tekle-Haymanot was crowned in 1706 before the death of his father and was in turn assassinated by Tewoflos in 1708. Tewoflos was again killed in 1711 by Yostos, who was also poisoned in 1717 and replaced by Dawit III, who himself was poisoned and replaced by Bakafa in 1721. Bakafa tried to restore stability with the support of his followers

and his wife *Etege* Mentewab until he was incapacitated in 1728. The Gondarine Period also witnessed increased involvement of the Oromo in Imperial politics and the army as will be discussed shortly.

From 1728 to 1768, *Etege* Mentewab together with her brother *Ras*-Bitwaded Walda Le'ul (1732-1767) dominated the Gondarine court politics. Walda Le'ul was influential during the reigns of Iyasu II (1730-55) and Iyoas (1755-69). Following his death in 1767, *Etege* Mentewab was challenged by Wubit Amito, her daughter-in-law from Wollo. To counter the growing power of the Wollo Oromo in the royal court, Mentewab sought the alliance of *Ras* Mika'el Sehul of Tigray who was politically astute and militarily powerful. Mika'el Sehul succeeded in stabilizing the situation but refused to return to Tigray although demanded by Iyoas. This was followed by the killing of Iyoas and his replacement by an old man Yohannes II by *Ras* Mika'el. Soon *Ras* Mika'el killed Yohannes II and put his son Takla-Haymanot II (1769-77) on power. This marked the onset of the period of *Zemene-Mesafint* (1769-1855).

B. Achievements of the Gondarine Period

Gondar became the center of state administration, learning, commerce, education, art, and crafts for more than two centuries. The first three kings were successful not only in political affairs but also in cultural developments. Gondar had great influence on the country's cultural developments. This enabled Gondar to repeat the splendors of Aksum and Lalibela. The cultural achievements of the period led some writers to describe Gondarine period in history as Ethiopian Renaissance.

Architecture: when Gondar served as a permanent capital, for about one hundred fifty years, Ethiopian kings built significant secular buildings like castles, bridges, residences, bath, library, towers, fortifications and churches of various size and shapes.

In the city's compound, in addition to the most impressive building known as *Fasil Gemb*, there are different palaces corresponding to Emperor Fasiledas, Yohannes I, Iyasu I, Dawit III, Bakafa and Regent Queen Mentewab. The Gondarine style of architecture may have started before the reign of emperor Fasiledas during the reign of Emperor Sartsa-Dengle at

about 1586, as could be seen from his palace at Guzara near Enfranz. The architectural styles of Fasiledas castle usually have two strides and almost square, circular domed corner towers. Not only castles, but the building of bridges are said to be predate the reign of Fasiledas. Emperor Sartsa-Dengel is said to have built a very fine bridge near his palace at Guzara, and Emperor Susenyos likewise erected a bridge over Blue Nile at Alata.

Picture 4: Fasilidas's Castle in Gondar



Source: <https://www.britannica.com/place/Gondar#/media/1/238349/11150>

Painting: this period is known as for the production of a wealth of religious paintings on manuscripts and on wood, ornaments, weapons and other accessories. The churches built by Queen Mentwab were known for their beautiful paintings, cross and art works.

Literature: The Imperial and provincial scriptoria produced a great number of manuscripts. Besides the Gospels, the Miracles of Mary, the Lives of Ethiopian Saints and the Litanies, many other kinds of illuminated manuscripts were also produced. Gondar is also known for its traditional medicine, music and poetry.

Trade and Urbanization: Gondar was a commercial center that connected long distance trade routes of the southern region with Massawa and Metemma in the Ethio-Sudan border. Gold and salt were used as medium of exchange. Daily markets were commonly held in the city. With spread of urbanization, the city became residences of foreign communities like Indians, Greeks and Armenians. The city had an estimated 60,000-70,000 population. In

addition to its political and commercial importance, it served as religious center of Christians, Muslims and Bete-Israel. Besides, it served as the center of Ethiopian Orthodox Church until the middle of the nineteenth century. Many of the Orthodox churches which served as education centers, known for their excellence in teaching *aqwaqwam*, liturgical chanting were centered at Gondar.

5.6.2. The Period of *Zemene-Mesafint* (1769-1855)

Zemene-Mesafint refers to the period when actual political power was in the hands of different regional lords. The period lasted from the time Ras Michael Sehul "assassinated" king Iyoas in 1769 to 1855, when Kasa Hailu was crowned as Tewodros II.

Ras Mika'el who was a king-maker in the period attempted to dominate the other regional lords. These measures made him highly unpopular because of which coalitions of lords of Gojjam, Amhara, Lasta and Wollo fought and defeated him at the battle of Sarba-Kussa in 1771. Under the reigns of his successors, there was relative stability but several regional lords evolved. The main political regions that *Zemene-Mesafint* lords ruled were Tigray, Semen, Dembiya, Begemidir, Lasta, Yejju, Wollo, Gojjam and Shewa. When compared to each other the "Yejju dynasty" was the leading power during the Zemen-Mesafint with the center at Debre-tabor. Ali Gwangul (Ali I or Ali Talaq) was considered as the founder of "Yejju dynasty" in 1786.

Yejju rule reached its zenith under Gugsu Marso (r.1803-1825) who made incessant struggle against Ras Walde-Silassie of Enderta and *Dejjazmatch* Sabagadis Woldu of Agame. In 1826, Gugsu's successor, Yimam (r.1825-8), defeated Hayle-Mariam Gebre of Simen. Maru of Dambiya was also killed at the battle of Koso-Ber in 1827. The period of *Zemene Mesafint* was brought to an end by Kasa Hailu of Qwara through a series of battles that lasted from 1840s to 1855.

Major features of *Zemene-Mesafint* include:

- absence of effective central government;
- the growing power and influence of the regional warlords;
- the domination of Yejju lords over other lords in northern Ethiopia;

- rivalry and competition among regional lords to assume the position of king-maker;
- establishment of fragile coalitions to advance political interests;
- Ethiopian Orthodox Church was unable to play its traditional role of unifying the state due to doctrinal disputes;
- Revival of foreign contacts that ended the “closed-door” policy.

In addition to the above features, there were developments in terms of literature, arts, architecture etc during the period.

Learning Activities

- Why was Imam’s force successful at the battle of Shimbra Kure?
- Why did Portugal and Ottoman Turkey involve in the domestic affairs of the Horn in the sixteenth century?
- What were the major effects of the conflicts between the Christian kingdom and Muslim Sultanates?
- What was the ‘close door policy’ and how did it affect Ethiopia’s relations with the outside world?
- Discuss the process and outcome of the Jesuits’ evangelical activities in Ethiopia.
- Why do you think Susenyos adopted Catholicism as a state religion?
- Discuss the role of the *Chewa* system in the intermingling of peoples along the borders between the Christian and Muslim inhabited areas.
- Discuss the causes of population movements in the sixteenth century?
- Explain the contributions of the Oromo, Argoba, Afar and Somali population movements to Ethiopia’s present socio-cultural conditions?
- What was the purpose of the *buttaa* ceremony and how did it function in the context of the Oromo population movement in the sixteenth century?
- What is the *Gadaa* system and how did it function in Oromo society?
- Which values of the *Gadaa* system contributed to social integration?
- Discuss the similarities and differences between *Gadaa*, *Luwa* and *Baalle* systems of the Oromo, Sidama and Gedeo respectively.
- Discuss the evolution and political administration of the following polities.

Kambata

Wolayta

The Emirate of Harar

- Discuss the circumstances that gave rise to the Zemene-Mesafint.
- List the major features of the Zemene-Mesafint and analyze how such conditions affect societies?
- Explain key developments during the period of the *Yejju* dynasty.
- Briefly describe major achievements of the Gondarine period.

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History of Ethiopia and the Horn Module (Hist.1102)

UNIT SIX

INTERNAL DEVELOPMENTS AND EXTERNAL RELATIONS OF ETHIOPIA AND THE HORN, 1800-1941 (10 hours)

Introduction

This unit surveys the history of the region from the early nineteenth century to 1941. The unit begins in 1800 as many of the states in the southern half of the country emerged or flourished around this period. The unit tries to explain continuous and complex interactions and external relations that shaped the region's modern history. The region experienced the expansion of trade, state formations, territorial expansion and creation of modern Ethiopia, modernization, and major battles fought to repulse foreign aggression. In the nineteenth century, several autonomous and semi-autonomous states existed at different stages of socio-economic and political developments. The economic activities ranged from hunting and gathering to a well-developed agriculture and trade. The political organizations of some of the states were monarchical system in nature while some others followed political systems of different kinds. Despite the independent existence of peoples and states, they maintained strong economic, social and political relations with one another that created strong interdependence in the region. It is apparent that territorial expansion of the late nineteenth century was made to control lucrative resource bases and trade routes and thereby form a strong Ethiopian state. Simultaneously, Ethiopia and the Horn fought major battles against the imposition of colonial rule and resisted foreign domination as can be seen from the patriotic resistance. This unit also explains the role of various personalities in confrontations against colonial powers.

Unit Objectives

At the end of this unit, students will be able to:

- point out the different states that existed in Ethiopia and the Horn before the formation of modern Ethiopia;
- analyze the political system, culture and economy of the autonomous and semi-autonomous peoples and states of the period;

- discuss the significances of agriculture and trade in the economy of the region;
- explain the process of territorial expansion of the Shewan Kingdom that led to the formation of modern Ethiopia; and
- appreciate the Ethiopian resistance against foreign powers.

Unit Starters

- Share orally with your classmates the role played by long-distance trade in the relations between peoples of Ethiopia.
- What was the enduring interest of Ethiopian monarchs and regional leaders in establishing contacts with the outside world? What major obstacles did they encounter in the process?
- What role did the nineteenth century territorial expansion play in the interaction and integration of peoples in Ethiopia and the Horn?

6.1. The Nature of Interactions among Peoples and States of Ethiopia and the Horn

At the beginning of the nineteenth century, many autonomous and semi-autonomous peoples and states existed in Ethiopia and the Horn. This section deals with the history of these peoples and states in the period under consideration.

6.1.1. Peoples and States in South-Central, Southwestern, and Western Ethiopia

A. South-Central: Hadiya, Halaba, Kambata and Gurage were autonomous and semi-autonomous political entities during this period. Economically, they depended largely on agriculture. Local merchants were actively involved in local trade and to some extent in the long distance trade. Trade routes that connected the interior with the coast passed through these territories. Among these, the Gurage land was an important market centre and political entity. Important trade centers such as Soddo and Aymallel were located in the Gurage land. The Gurage had their own political organization and their leaders held the titles of *Abegaz* or *Azmatch* who combined political and military authority.

In the second half of the nineteenth century, Qabena emerged as a strong political entity. It became a centre of Muslim revivalist movement to the northeast of the Gibe River. Stirred by Muslim refugees from Wollo, and with possible connections even with the Mahdist Sudan,

the movement swept across a large part of the region and was attended by a fast spread of Islam.

B. The Gibe States: towards the beginning of the nineteenth century, several monarchical states (*motumma*) emerged among the Mecha Oromo at the expense of the *Gadaa* system. Many factors accounted for the transformation of the *Gadaa* system. In the process, the war leaders of the *Gadaa* system (*Abba-Dula*) and powerful individuals usurped the power of the *Gadaa* government. The *abba-dula* accumulated wealth from the control and taxation on long distance trade and utilized the opportunity to establish hereditary leadership. This development especially took place among the Oromo around Gibe, where the following five monarchical states emerged.

- i. **Limmu-Enarya:** Limmu-Enarya was the earliest of the Gibe states. It was founded through the incorporation of Enarya. Initially, Abbaa Dulas of Limmu like Tesso fought and defeated the rulers of Enarya like Badancho, Gu'amcho and Banaro at different times. Finally, Bofoo/Abba Gomol (1800-1825) established Limmu-Enarya. Bofo abdicated in favor of his son, Ibsa/Abba Bagiboo (1825-61). The Kingdom reached the height of its power during Ibsa's reign, when he incorporated areas including Hagalo, Badi-Folla etc. Ibsa was succeeded by Abba Bulgu (1861-1883).
- ii. **Gumma:** Jilcha Abba Bal'oo of Chira killed Sarbaroda of Dagoye clan; began state formation and succeeded by his son Oncho (1810-1830) who was in turn followed by Jawwe (1840-1854).
- iii. **Gomma:** formed by Abba Bokee (1800-1829) who was succeeded by his son Abba Manoo (1829-1840) who occupied Qattuu and converted to Islam by Muslim Ulama/scholars.
- iv. **Jimma:** Towards the late eighteenth century, Makahore emerged as an influential female figure among the Sadacha Mecha Oromo of Jimma. The local Abba Dula sought to take political power from her. Among the *Abba Dulas*, Ose Kobi (Abba Faro) was elected as a hereditary ruler against the *Gadaa* rule. He was succeeded by Dangila (Abba Magal) who enlarged the domain. The process of state formation was completed by Sanna/Abba Jifar I (r.1830-55) who formed Jimma Kingdom and left a consolidated state to his successors like Abba Rebu (1855-59), Abba Boqa (1859-1861) and Abba Gomol(r.1861-75). The

most famous among the Jimma monarchs was Abba Jifar II (c. r.1875-1934). Apart from agriculture and trade, the kingdom's economy depended on iron mining and smelting at Dakkano and Kito, respectively.

- v. **Gera:** was the last of the Gibe kingdoms to be formed. The process of state formation in Gera was completed during the reign of Tullu Gunji (r.1835-38), a successful war leader who made himself king. Abba Rago I (r.1838-48) succeeded Tullu Gunji after a short interlude by Abba Basso. Gera enjoyed its prosperity under Abba Magal who had been converted to Islam. As with other Gibe states, Gera attracted Muslim missionaries to preach Islam.

C. The Leqa States

Like in the Gibe region, several monarchical kingdoms evolved among the Mecha Oromo of Wallagga. Among these were the Leqa states, the Sibbu and the Jawwi south of the Abbay River. While *Moti* Abishe established strong kingdom of Horro, a number of *Abba Dulas* declared themselves *moti* (king) by controlling profitable trade routes and large territories in the region west of the Gibe region. Among these, the Leqa states were the prominent ones.

- I. **Leqa-Naqamte:** was founded by Bakare Godana in 1840, and reached its height under his successors Moroda and Kumsa. The latter were able to establish strong monarchical state rich in trade and agriculture. *Moti* Kumsa (later *Dejazmach* Gebre-Egzi'abiher) was known for promoting handcraft work, gold washing, coffee planting and game reserves/hunting. The Leqa-Naqamte rulers instituted a new administrative structure and judicial hierarchy that replaced the *Gadaa* system known as *sirna abba-qoro* (*qoro* system). In its nature, the administration system was essentially kingship and was quite similar to feudal administration in its reliance on land.

- II. **Leqa-Qellam:** was located in southwestern Wallagga. It was founded by Tullu and became powerful under his son, Jote being centered at Gidami and controlling the areas around Sayyo-Dambi Dollo.

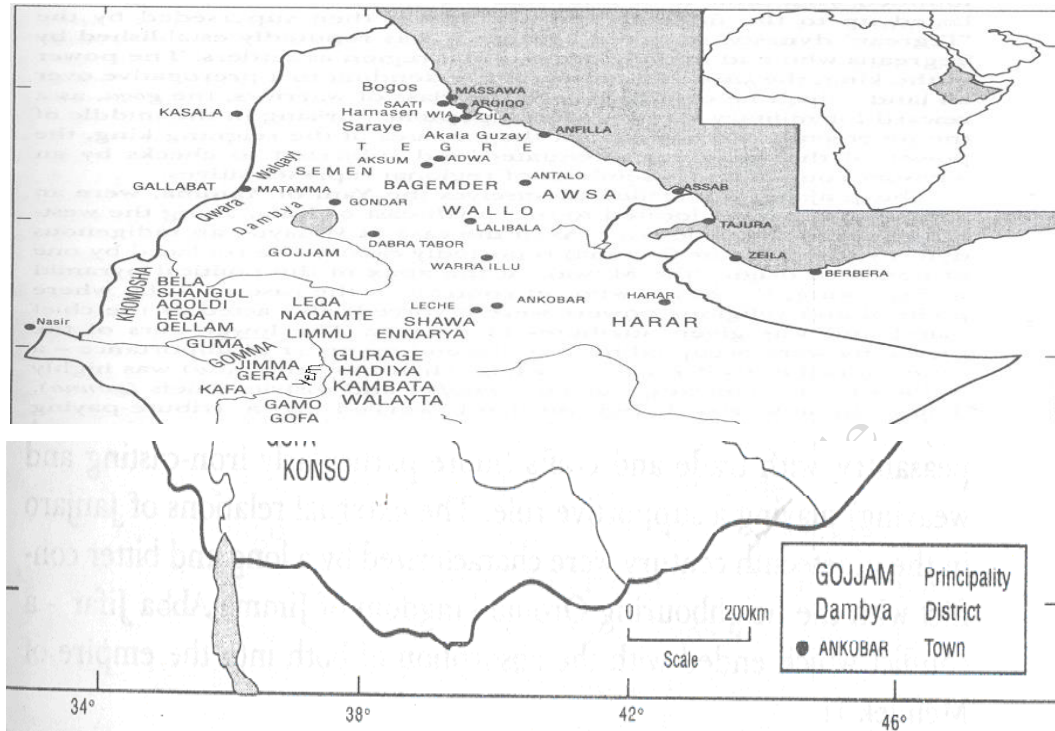
D. Ilu: the Tume clan leader Chali Shono (also known as Abba Bor) set up the well-consolidated state of Ilu-Abba Bor in the early nineteenth century. It was one of the prosperous states in the region.

Each Oromo monarchical state had officials like *Abba Gurmu* (next person to the king), *Abba Mizan* (treasurer and foreign affair minister), *Abba Dango* (immigration chief), *Lammi* (ambassador/royalmessenger), *Abba Qoro* (district governor), *Abba Ganda* (village chief), *Abba Busi* (tax head), *Abba Jiga* (murder judge) and *Abba-Qawe* (body-guard). Contrary to the *Gadaa* values that did not levy any kind of taxation, under monarchical systems farmers were forced to pay crop tax measured by traditional instruments called *buchano* (about 15 kilograms) and later *guboo* (25 kilograms) on each crop.

E. Nilotic Sheikdoms: in the early nineteenth century, important Islamic centres emerged in the lower course of the Abbay. A number of Shiekdoms were established through parallel imposition of Arabic-speaking Sudanese mercantilists over Berta and Gumuz inhabitants. Among them, the Sheikhdoms of Assosa or Aqoldi, Bela Shangul and Khomosha were established to the south of Abbay River and the Sheikhdome of Guba emerged to the north of the same river in the western edge of Gojjam. The four sheikhdoms were founded by Muslim leaders of Sudanese origin who considered themselves as 'Watawit'. The term Watawit refers to Arabized Berta people who had entered and settled in Benishangul as traders and Islamic religious teachers in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. The main economic bases of the sheikdoms were agriculture, gold mining and frontier trade. Among these sheikhdoms, Asosa got preeminence under Sheikh Khojale al Hasan. While Bela/Beni-Shangul became famous under Abd al Rahman Khojale, Khomosha reached its zenith under Khojale Muhammad Wad Mahmud. Similarly, Guba was founded to the north of the Abbay River along the Ethio-Sudanese border.

The influence of Islam from the Sudan and cross border trade was the main reasons for the rise of these states. The rich gold of the region also attracted foreign powers like the Egyptians and Mahdists who attempted to control the sheikdoms at different times.

Map 6: Peoples and States of Ethiopia and the Horn, c. 1800



Source: Bahru Zewde, *A History of Modern Ethiopia, 1855—1991* (Addis Ababa, AAU Press, 2002), p. 17.

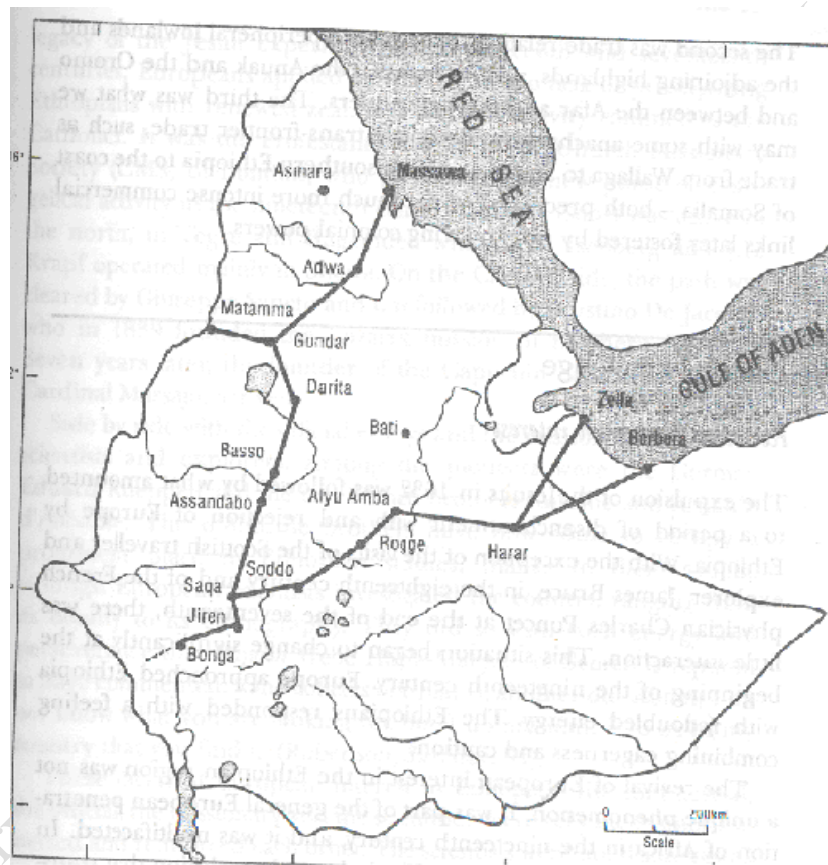
6.1.2. Trade and Trade Routes

Although the trade routes which linked southwestern Ethiopia to the coast had medieval antecedents, it was in the nineteenth century that they attained particular prominence. This was partly because of the revival of external trade in the Red Sea region. As a result, trade became one means of maintaining strong relations across peoples of different areas and backgrounds. During this period, two main trade lines linked various territories of Ethiopia and the Horn. One route originated from Bonga, the capital of Kafa Kingdom, linked peoples and states of the southwestern Ethiopia with the northern part of the Ethiopian region. The main market centers along this line were Bonga, Hirmata (in Jimma), Saqa (in Limmu), Billo (in Leqa-Naqamte), Asandabo (in Guduru), Basso-Yajube (in Gojjam), Yifag and Darita (in Begemider) and Gondar. From Gondar, one line bifurcated to westward through Chilga to Matamma-Qallabat (Gallabat) taking commodities to be sold to the Sudanese merchants called *Jallaba*. The other route passed through Adwa, Asmara and entered Massawa. Still

another split at Basso to move via Ancharro and Dawwe in Wollo and Awusa in Afar to Tajura, Obbok and Rahe'ita in Djibouti.

The second major trade route also began from Bonga and passed through Hirmata to Agabja-Andode-Toli to Soddo in southwest Shewa; Rogge near Yerer. Then, the line passed through Aliyu Amba or Abdul Rasul in northern Shewa and ran eastward to Harar. From Harar, the route branched into Zeila and Berbera, the most important commercial centers in Somalia. Then Ethiopian products were mostly sold in the Middle East.

Map 7: Trade Routes of Ethiopia and the Horn in the Nineteenth century



Source: Bahru Zewde, *A History of Modern Ethiopia, 1855—1991* (Addis Ababa, AAU Press, 2002), p. 23.

In the trade between the interior and the coast, varieties of items were exchanged. The main sources of exported items were the southwestern regions. Among these were gold, ivory, rhinoceros horn, skins, civet, musk, honey, wax, coffee, various spices and slaves. Slaves were either raided or bought from different parts of Ethiopia and exported to Arabia, Persia and India. Likewise, imported products included mirrors and ironware. The major medium

of exchange were salt bars (*amole*), iron bars, wines, cowries' shells, beads, pieces of cotton cloth (*abujadi*), Maria Theresa Thalers (MTT), etc. For internal trade, *amole* was the major important commodity and source of wealth. It was mined in the Afar plains bordering eastern Tigray where it was also suitably shaped for transportation. Then, it was transported from the region to the highlands through Adwa, Gondar, and to south and southwestern parts of the region. The other route took salt from eastern Tigray to south Wollo and Shewa. The town of Mekelle prospered as the salt was cut in and distributed to the highlands from the area under the supervision of the governor of Enderta with the title of *Balgada*, who collected the tributes as tax judge, and grew in importance and rivaling the *Bahre-Negash* (the governor of the maritime province to the north). MTT was a coin introduced from Austria to the Horn of African region at the end of the eighteenth century. On the Red Sea Coast, MTT was used with other kinds of European and Middle Eastern coins.

Diverse peoples of different ethnic and religious background were involved in the trade. At each market center, local peoples were active traders. However, Muslim merchants were the most dominant that traveled from interior to the coast. Among these were northern Muslim merchants (*Jabarti*) and Muslim Oromo merchants of southwestern region known as *Afqala*. Similarly, the Argoba from the Kingdom of Shewa were active merchants in the trade between Harar and the northern Somali coast.

6.2. The Making of Modern Ethiopian State

As discussed in the previous units, the diverse peoples of Ethiopia and the Horn were brought into contact through the agency of trade, population movements, evangelization, and wars. These agencies played an important part in the making of the modern Ethiopian state. On the other hand, a number of autonomous and semi-autonomous peoples and polities were in existence in many regions up to the end of the nineteenth century. During the nineteenth century, several states that emerged in the region were involved in territorial competition not only to extend control over resources but also for state building. To put it differently, state building remained an agenda of several powerful individuals and groups that arose in the nineteenth century. The difference was the level of their strength and ambition, and their relations with foreign powers. States in the northern and central parts of Ethiopia had relative

strength that were built up over time and gained a new momentum during the nineteenth century owing to their foreign contacts and their strategic location.

The making of the modern Ethiopian state went through two distinct phases. The first one involved unifying different regions and peoples in north and north central parts of Ethiopia. The second phase involved territorial expansion into the southern parts of the country. Hereunder, the processes of unification and territorial expansion are discussed in some detail.

A. The Process of Territorial Unification

The territorial unification ushered in a revival of the imperial power, which had declined during the *Zemene-Mesafint*. This occurred after a series of battles and human and material losses. A leading figure in the overall process was Kasa Hailu of Quara who later became Emperor Tewodros II of Ethiopia. Kasa's mission to create a unified state goes back to the time when he was a *shifta*. It is better to trace the origin of Kassa's ideas to the tradition of a once unified Ethiopian state. The myth behind his throne name "Tewodros" makes this clear

As indicated above, the man who ended the *Zemene Mesafint* was Kasa Hailu. He started his career by assisting his half-brother, *Dejjazmach* Kinfu in defeating the Egyptians at Wad Kaltabu (in present-day eastern Sudan) in 1837. As he acquired military and political strength and experiences, he started mobilizing his own army in the area and fought battles in his own right. In 1848, Kasa fought against the Egyptians at a place called Dabarki (again in present Sudan). Although they showed extraordinary courage, Kasa's forces lost the battle owing to the Egyptians' superior military organization, discipline, and better arms. Notwithstanding his defeat, Kasa drew a lesson pertaining to the importance of a modern army. On the other hand, Kasa's fame was spreading in the area and became a major concern to the Warra-Sheh (Yejju) ruling house. As a result, they decided to pacify Kasa through marriage arrangement. Hence, Kasa married Mentwab, the daughter of *Ras* Ali II and he was appointed the governor of Quara. However, Kasa felt that he was not well treated by *Ras* Ali and his mother, *Etege* Menen, and hence, he resumed his *shiftnet* resulting in a series of battles. Accordingly, Kasa defeated *Dejjach* Goshu Zewde of Gojjam at Gur Amba on November 27, 1852; Birru Aligaz, Aben, Yazew and Belew, the four *dejjazmachs* sent by *Ras* Ali, at Taqusa (Gorgora Bichign) on April 12, 1853; *Ras* Ali at Ayshal on 29 June 1853 and *Dejjazmach* Wube of

Simen and Tigray at Deresge on 8 February, 1855. After defeating the major regional lords one after another, he was anointed by *Abune* Salama, the Coptic bishop at Deresge Mariam on 9 February 1855, with the throne name of Tewodros II (1855-1868), King of Kings of Ethiopia.

Tewodros pursued his victory at Deresge by marching to the south. He subsequently marched first to Wollo and then to Shewa. He wanted to create a strong central government by appointing individuals (both hereditary and non-hereditary) who would be totally accountable to him. However, he faced resistance soon after he came to power. After the inclusion of Shewa, rebellions broke out in several regions such as in Gojjam, Simen, Wag and Lasta, Shewa, Wollo, and Tigray. Externally, he was involved in a serious diplomatic crisis following the imprisonment of a handful of Britons and other Europeans. As a result, the British government sent an expeditionary force to free those prisoners and punish the emperor. In a battle that took place at Maqdela, Emperor Tewodros committed suicide on April 13, 1868.

Following the death of Emperor Tewodros, three contenders to the throne emerged; namely, *Wagshum* Gobeze of Lasta, Kasa Mircha of Tigray and Menilek of Shewa. Gobeze took state power immediately after Tewodros as Emperor Tekle-Giorgis II (1868–71). Although attempts were made to create a smooth relation between the Emperor and Kasa Mircha, the quest for state power put them in enmity and it was brought to an end following a battle at Assam (near Adwa) in July 1871, in which the latter became victorious. Kasa, who became Emperor Yohannes IV in January 1872, embarked on a state building project with an approach that differed from that of Tewodros. Yohannes IV (1872-1889) attempted to introduce a decentralized system of administration, permitting regional rulers to exercise a great deal of autonomy. A good example of this was his recognition of Menilek as *Negus* of Shewa in 1878 by the Liche agreement. Similarly, Yohannes designated *Ras* Adal Tesema of Gojjam as *Negus* Tekle-Haymanot of Gojjam and Kafa in 1881. He succeeded in achieving the unity of the predominantly-Christian provinces including Wag and Lasta, Simen, Begemidr, Amhara Saynt, Gojjam, Wollo, Shewa, and the Mereb Milash for quite some time.

Emperor Yohannes IV sought to end the religious controversy within the EOC as well as effect religious unity in the country as a whole. In this regard, he presided over the Council of Boru Meda (1878) where Tewahdo was declared the only doctrine of the EOC. This was followed by a campaign to convert Muslims and adherents of other religions into Orthodox Christianity. Accordingly, the leading Wollo leaders such as Mohammed Ali and Amede Liben heeded the Emperor's call, rather reluctantly, converting to Christianity and changing their names to *Ras Michael* and *Dajjach Hayle-Mariam*, respectively. Others accepted the Emperor's demand outwardly but remained Muslims, becoming "Christians by day and Muslims by night". Others resisted and fled Wollo to Arsi, Gurage, Jimma and the Sudan while others revolted under the leadership of Sheikh Tola (Talha) Jafar that led to harsh measures of Emperor Yohannes IV.

Externally, Emperor Yohannes faced challenges from Egyptians, Italians, and the Mahdists at different times. He lost his life fighting the latter at Metemma in 1889. Although the Emperor had designated Mengesha Yohannes as his successor, rivalry for power split the monarch's camp and thus, Mengesha was unable to make a viable bid for the imperial throne. As a result, the throne was assumed by *Negus Menilek* of Shewa who became Emperor Menilek II (1889-1913). *Ras Mengesha* refused to submit to Emperor Menilek. The tension was resolved after Menilek led a campaign to force Mengesha's submission in 1889. *Ras Mengesha* was appointed as governor of Tigray after a temporary arrangement in which *Ras Mekonnen Wolde Mikael* ruled the area for about a year.

B. Territorial Expansion

As indicated above, Emperor Tewodros II, Emperor Yohannes IV and others made state building their mission and struggled to achieve that goal. Yet, the most successful was Menilek of Shewa. This was because Menilek had, among other factors, access to modern firearms. The control of resource rich areas that enabled the emperor to build military muscle as well as the determination of his generals counted for his successes. The process of territorial expansion by Menilek can be discussed in three phases i.e. when he was king of Shewa (1865-89), from 1889-96 and the aftermath of Adwa (1896-1900).

Before the 1870s, Menilek had already incorporated the Tulema and eastern Mecha Oromo territories after controlling local leaders notably Ashe Rufo of Salale, Dula Ara'e of Gullale, Tufa Muna of Gimbichu, Ture Galate of Soddo and others. Meanwhile, other Oromo elites such as *Ras Gobena Dache*, *Fitawrari Habte-Giorgis Dinagde*, *Dejjach Balcha Safo (Abba Nefso)* and others worked towards the formation of the modern Ethiopian state.

In 1875-76, the northern Gurage, the Kistane, peacefully submitted to Menilek because of their religious affinity and geographical proximity to the Kingdom of Shewa, and for fear of their local rivals notably the surrounding Oromo. On the other hand, the western Gurage, led by Hasan Enjamo of Qabena, which had elements of Hadiya-Gurage coalition, strongly resisted Menilek's force until *Ras Gobena* broke their resistance in 1888.

Menilek's territorial expansion to western and southwestern regions was concluded through both forceful and peaceful submissions. In the regions south of the Abbay River, particularly in Horro Guduru, *Ras Adal Tesema* of Gojjam had already established his control over the region since the mid-1870s. Although he faced stiff resistance from *Moti* (King) *Abishe Garba* of Horro, Adal's force ambushed Abishe and his entourage at a place called Kokor. Thus, *Ras Adal (Nigus Tekle-Haymanot since 1881)* controlled the region until 1882, when he was defeated at Embabo by Menilek's commander, *Ras Gobana*.

After the Battle of Embabo, *Leqa-Naqamte*, *Leqa-Qellem*, and *Jimma Abba Jifar* submitted to Menilek peacefully, who promised them to recognize and maintain their autonomy. Meanwhile, *Garbi Jilo* (of *Leqa-Billo*), *Tucho Dano* (*Leqa-Horda*), *Ligdi Bakare* (*Leqa-Naqamte*), *Genda Busan* (*Sibu-Sire*), *Mardasa Konche* (*Nonno Migira*), and *Turi Jagan* (*Nonno Rogge*) formed a coalition and defeated Menilek's army led by the Nadew brothers, *Dasta*, *Dilinesaw* and *Tesemma* at the Battle of *Gurra Doba*. Similarly, west of the *Dhiddessa* River, an alliance of *Wachu Dabalo* of *Sibu*, *Jorgo Dagago* of *Noole Kabba* and others fought Menilek's local allies like *Moroda* and *Amante Bakare* at *Sambo Darro*. Later, however, they were defeated.

In the Gibe region, *Firissa* of *Guma* fought Menilek's army from 1889 to 1901. The imperial army faced similar resistance from *Abba Bosso* of *Gomma*, although defeated by *Ras*

Demisew Nesibu in early 1900. Also, *Ras Tesemma Nadew's* force incorporated Ilu Abba Bor into the imperial state after fighting with Fatansa at Qarsa Gogila.

Of all the campaigns *Nigus Menilek* conducted before he became emperor, perhaps, the most sustained bloody wars were those against the Arsi Oromo. It took six different campaigns from 1882-6 to control this vast region. Menilek encountered fierce resistance from the Arsi Oromo led by notables like Sufa Kuso, Damu Usu, Lenjiso Diga, Gosa Dilamo and Roba Butta. Initially, the Arsi Oromo defeated Menilek's force at Dodota and Qalata. Yet, with intelligence service of local supporters, *Ras Darge Sahile-Selassie's* force defeated the Arsi Oromo at the battle of Azule on 6 September 1886. The battle of Azule was followed by what is known as the Anole incident of 1887, which inflicted heavy damage on the Arsi. [There is disagreement among historians on the veracity of the incident and on whether there is a need to highlight it, as the campaigns of territorial expansion were often attended by atrocities as was the case for instance in Kafa and Walayta].

In the east, Menilek's commander, *Dejjach Wolde-Gabra'el*, fought against the Itu in 1886 and incorporated Chercher. A year later, *Dejjach Mekonnen's* army marched into Harar. The resisting forces of Emir Abdullahi (r.1885-1887) of the Harari and Bakar Ware of the Eastern Oromo were defeated in the final engagement at Chalanqo on 6 January 1887. This was followed by the appointment of *Dejjach* (later *Ras*) Makonnen Wolde Mikael as governor of the province by Emperor Menilek II.

The Great Famine or *Kifu Qen* (Evil Day) of 1888-92 also contributed to Menilek's territorial expansion to parts of southern Ethiopia. Accordingly, Menilek's army occupied Dawuro-Konta and Kambata in 1889 and 1890, respectively. From the early 1890s to 1894, Menilek's army controlled Bale, Sidama, Gamo Gofa and Wolayta. In the campaign to Wolayta, Emperor Menilek and many notables such as *Ras Mikael* of Wollo, *Fitawurari* Gebeyehu Gurmu, *Liqe Mekwas* Abate Buayalew, *Dejjach Balcha Safo*, *Ras Wolde-Giorgis*, and Abba Jifar II of Jimma participated. Wolayta's resistance led by *Kawo* (King) Tona against Menilek's force was defeated in 1894 in which large number of people lost their lives. This was followed by the incorporation of Gedeo, Borana and Konso into the imperial state.

Menilek's force incorporated Kafa, Borana Beni-Shangul, and Gambella after the battle of Adwa. The process of the incorporation of Kafa paralleled the Wolayta experience in terms of human cost. In 1897, the king of Kafa, *Tato Gaki Sherocho*, fought and lost to Menilek's army led by *Ras Wolde Giorgis*. Beni-Shangul was incorporated after the Battle of Fadogno in 1897/98. This was followed by the occupation of Maji in 1898/99. Tesema Nadew also controlled Baro (Sobat) and Nasir in Gambella around this time.

The process of territorial expansion was consummated with the signing of boundary agreements with the neighboring colonial powers that continued until 1908. Most of these treaties were signed after the victory of Adwa.

After Menilek, the process of centralization and establishing a unitary state continued by abolishing regional autonomies in the early decades of the twentieth century. In the process, Wollo (after the battle of Segele in 1916 when *Nigus Mika'el* was defeated), Begemedir (after the battle of Anchim at which *Ras Gugsu Wole* was defeated in 1930), Gojjam in 1932 and Jimma in 1933 were reduced to mere provinces by Teferi-Mekonnen (Haile-Sillassie I).

6.3. Modernization Attempts

The period from 1800 to 1941 also witnessed efforts to adopt western ideas and technology by Ethiopian monarchs. Although several Ethiopian regional rulers were interested in European technologies, Emperor Tewodros had relatively better information/contact about western technologies than his predecessors. He was well aware of the importance of European technologies to transform his people and country. For this purpose, he attempted to approach Europeans for the introduction of western science and technologies.

It is apparent that, Kasa's defeat by the well-trained and equipped Egyptian troops at the Battle of Dabarki in 1848 had made him think putting the country "on an equal footing with European powers." As a monarch, Tewodros took a number of military, administrative and socio-economic reform measures. As regards the army, Tewodros introduced military titles, like *Yasr Aleqa*, *Yamsa Aleqa*, and *Yeshi Aleqa*. Besides, he tried to organize and replace the regional armies of the *Zemene-Mesafint* with salaried national army. Furthermore, he tried to

manufacture firearms at his workshop, Gafat (near Debre Tabor) with the help of European missionaries and artisans. At Gafat, about 35 cannons were produced of which the biggest one was known as “Sebastopol.” He also tried to build a small navy in Lake Tana. The administrative reforms of Tewodros were focused on the centralization of power and securing financial base. He introduced a policy of “general pacification”, warning that everyone should return to his lawful vocation, the merchant to his store, and the farmer to his plough. He tried to separate church and the monarchy. He tried to reduce the amount of land held by the church as well as the number of priests and deacons serving every church. brought him into conflict with the EOC, which precipitated his downfall.

In the case of socio-economic reforms, he began the construction of Ethiopia’s first embryonic road network to link Debre Tabor with Gondar, Gojjam, and Maqdela. He also attempted to put an end to the slave trade. Other reform attempts include land reform and banning of polygamy. The use of Amharic writing became more developed, and a traditional library was established at Maqdala, all of which contributed to the development of literary Amharic.. He wrote letters after letters to different foreign powers including to Queen Victoria using Amharic language. With regard to religion, he tried to solve the doctrinal controversy that continued from the 17th century within the EOC. However, his reforms were not fully materialized owing to internal oppositions and external challenges.

Emperor Yohannes' reign also witnessed several important reforms and innovations. Among these, he was the first Ethiopian monarch to appoint foreign consul who served as his representative in London. He hired a French mechanic, a Hungarian gunsmith, and an Italian construction worker to assist his modernization efforts of the country. Furthermore, he sent some individuals abroad for modern education. He was also the first to introduce modern style vaccine against smallpox replacing traditional inoculation. His reign also witnessed extensive treatment of syphilis in several towns.

Modernization attempts of the reign of Emperor Menilek had diverse elements. The post-Adwa period was marked by the establishment of a postal service and telecommunications/ the telephone-telegraph system, the construction of railway line from Djibouti to Addis Ababa, the opening of a bank (the Bank of Abyssinia) and the introduction of silver coin. In

terms of administration, the emperor introduced European style ministerial system/ministers in 1907. Accordingly, he appointed *Afe-Nigus* Nesibu Meskelo (Minister of Justice), *Azazh* Metaferia Melke-Tsadiq (Minister of Imperial Court), *Bejirond* Mulugeta Yigezu (Minister of Finance), *Fitawurari* Habte-Giorgis Dinagde (Minister of War), *Negadras* Hailegiorgis Weldemikael (Minister of Commerce and Foreign Relations), and *Tsehafe-Tizaz* Gebreselase Welde Aregay (Minister of Pen). His reign also witnessed the opening of a hotel in 1907 (*Itege* Hotel), a modern school (Menilek II School in 1908) and the foundation of Russian Red Cross hospital in 1906 and Russian-run hospital (Menilek II Hospital) in 1910.

After Emperor Menilek II faced permanent ailment that incapacitated him, he designated and eventually proclaimed *Lij* Iyasu and *Ras* Tesemma Nadew as heir to the throne and regent, respectively. During his short stay in power, *Lij* Iyasu (1913-16) also took several reform measures. The reforms are the banning of the *Quragna* system, a system that involved chaining the applicant and defendant as well as creditor and debtor until justice was settled. He tried to amend *Leba Shay*, a customary mode of detection of criminals or theft. He introduced municipal police called *Tirnbulle*. He introduced a policy of auditing of government accounts, and he tried to integrate Ethiopian Muslims into the administration structure. His rule also witnessed the introduction of a flourmill that functioned mechanically and private industrial enterprises like sawmill, a grinding-mill, a tannery, a soap-factory, etc.

During the Dual Rule of Empress Zewditu and *Ras* Teferi (r. 1916-1930), there were several modernization attempts in broader scope. The two rulers namely *Ras* Teferi and Empress Zewditu had different views towards western culture. Because of his close link with foreigners, *Ras* Teferi had keen interest in modernization by which he wanted to boost the country's image on the international stage. This was marked by the entry of Ethiopia into the League of Nations and his grand tour to Europe in 1923 and 1924, respectively. Some remarkable reforms based on European model took place following his coronation as Emperor Haile-Selassie I in 1930. Some of the reforms were the centralization of the government, promulgation of Ethiopia's first constitution in 1931 (despite its drawbacks), establishment of Imperial Body Guard in 1930, with the help of Belgian military mission and the opening of Ethiopia's first Military Academy at Holeta with the help of a Swedish military mission in 1934.

6.4. Socio-Economic Developments

The period from 1800 to 1941 was also marked by changes in socio-economic conditions including trade, slavery and slave trade, agriculture, urbanization and manufacturing. Factors for these changes included the socio-economic dynamics in the region and the world.

6.4.1. Agriculture and Land Tenure

The nineteenth and early twentieth centuries were times when agricultural economy grew and the demand for land for cultivation and grazing increased. The system favored the powerful groups to control land that resulted in the change of property right on the preexisting land tenure system. The role of agriculture in the local economy and the politics of the period could be understood from the territorial competition and expansions to control surplus producing areas. This altered people's relation to land, making some privileged and others unprivileged.

The quest for land and surplus production was one factor for territorial expansion by Menilek in the late nineteenth century. Land was required, among others, to settle and feed the warriors and their families. Hence, the incorporation of the southern half of the country into the imperial state resulted in the redefinition of access to resources in these regions. The state institutionalized different forms of surplus expropriation and mechanisms to ensure political control in the regions that had peacefully submitted and those that resisted. The former relatively enjoyed self-administration but were subjected to pay *qurt-gibir* (fixed tax). The latter were placed under the *nafteгна-gabbar/gabbar-nafteгна* system whereby local peoples were made to pay tribute to the former. Gradually, the *nafteгна-gabbar* system led to the evolution of a new tenure regime in the forcefully incorporated areas. Literally, *nafteгна* means a person with a gun. In this context, *nafteгна* refers to soldiers of different social backgrounds who were stationed in the southern territories under the imperial banner. In the latter case, the major force of change was the settlement and exploitative nature of the system that altered both settlement pattern and agricultural system. One effect of the institution of the *nafteгна-gabbar* system was the creation of classes like landlords, *ballabat*, *gabbar* and tenants. The landholders were largely government agents while the local population was reduced in time into *gabbar* and later tenants.

One major factor that brought change to agricultural practices including land tenure system was the beginning of the *qalad* system (land measurement) in the 1890s. Land measurement affected access to agricultural resources in diverse ways including changes to customary rules of access to land. *Qalad* introduced new practices in which certain social classes gained access to land while at the same time it resulted in the dispossession of the local peasantry in parts of the south. Later, land was categorized into *lam* (cultivated), *lam-taf* (partly-cultivated) and *taf* (uncultivated) to facilitate taxation.

6.4.2. Slavery and Slave Trade

Earlier in this unit, we have learned that both local and long-distance trade had flourished in the nineteenth century. The major commodities traded were ivory, slaves, civet, and gold.

Slavery and slave trade had long history in Ethiopia and the Horn. Most slaves in Ethiopia were kept as domestic slaves and some were sold to Egypt and the Middle East and the Ottoman Empire through the Sudan, the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden ports. During the nineteenth century, in some parts of Ethiopia, slaves were required for agricultural works, in the army and as sources of revenue through selling into slavery. Thus, several regional and local rulers enslaved people for these purposes. Slaves were traded as commodities in local and international markets. For instance, in 1837 slave raiders captured Bilile from Guma and sold her to a German prince, Herman Pickler Muskau at Cairo who changed her name to Mahbuba and made her his mistress. Similarly, Hika (later Onesimos Nasib) was kidnapped in 1869 in Hurumu when he was four years old. He was sold at Massawa, later freed by a Swedish mission, after which he translated the Bible into Afan Oromo at Menkulu (in Eritrea). Aster Gano was also sold into slavery from Limmu. However, in 1886, she was emancipated and assisted Onesimos in the translation of the Bible.

During the nineteenth century, slave trade expanded in Ethiopia and the Horn due to increased demand for slaves in foreign markets largely in the Middle East. This was followed by the emergence of market centers from Bonga to Metemma and Massawa. Selling slaves was source of revenue for many local chiefs. Slaves were acquired through raiding,

kidnapping, war captivity, debt bondage, and purchase from open markets. Major sources of slaves were southern and southwestern parts of Ethiopia.

Emperors Tewodros II, Yohannes IV and Menilek II tried to stop the slave trade although not slavery itself. In 1923, Ras Teferi banned slave trade which eventually came out in a decree in 1924 to emancipate slaves. This was followed by the establishment of the *Office for the Abolition of Slavery* in 1932. Freed slaves were kept under the overall supervision of *Hakim Warqineh Eshete*. The Italians proclaimed the abolition of slavery immediately after their occupation of the country. After liberation, the Emperor issued a new decree in 1942 abolishing any forms of slave trade and the institution of slavery itself.. The impact of slavery was obviously social and economic deterioration of the source areas, families and suffering of the slaves themselves.

6.4.3. Manufacturing

In many cultures in Ethiopia and the Horn, there were age-old indigenous ways of producing/making tools. Such manufacturing activities involved simple procedures and techniques and produced limited quantity of items. For instance, different items like furniture, dresses and food including local drinks, were produced and processed by using traditional techniques involving manual labor.

One result of the contact with the industrialized world from the mid nineteenth century was the introduction of manufacturing technologies. Although evidences do not trace the exact period of the beginning of modern industry in Ethiopia, there is a consensus that the strong interest of rulers in the region for the introduction of western technologies and the subsequent contacts with the industrial world since the mid nineteenth century contributed to the introduction of manufacturing industries.

The beginning of diplomatic relations and opening of legations in the post-Adwa period was followed by the coming of many expatriates, who either came with the skill or became agents of the introduction of modern manufacturing. Foreign citizens from Armenia, Greece, Italy and India also brought entrepreneurial capacity to develop manufacturing industries locally. Among modern manufacturing industries, Holeta Grain Mill and Massawa Salt Processing

were set up in 1896 and 1904, respectively. Up to 1927, about 25 factories were established in Addis Ababa, Dire Dawa, Asmara and Massawa. These included cement factories, wood and clay workshops, tanneries, soap and edible oil plants, ammunition factories, breweries, tobacco processing plants and grain mills. Private entrepreneurs established most of them. Among these, Artistic Printing Press and Ambo Mineral Water plant were established before the Italian occupation. After 1928, including in the short lived Italian occupation, more than ten manufacturing industries were set up.

6.4.4. Urbanization

The period from the early nineteenth century to 1941 marked the evolution of towns stemming from political, socio-economic, demographic and ecological factors. During the period, the expansion of both local and long distance trade since the early nineteenth century had transformed old markets and socio-political centers into towns in Ethiopia and the Horn. In this case, several towns located on the long-distance trade in western Ethiopia grew into towns. In addition, the beginning of railway connecting Djibouti and Addis Ababa as of 1917 was followed by the evolution of several fast growing towns. Towns including Dire-Dawa, Adama, Mojo, Bishoftu and others were results of the extension of the railway and the expansion of trade. On the other hand, politico-religious centers in several parts of the region evolved into towns. This was true mainly in the northern parts of Ethiopia. Many centers that once served as "royal camps" evolved into towns and parallel to this many towns declined with the demographic change when "royal camps" shifted to other centers. One of the towns that grew through such process was Addis Ababa. Empress Taytu Betul chose the place for its hot springs, Fel-Wuha (formerly called *Hora* Finfinne). Similarly, as of the late nineteenth century, in southern Ethiopia, a number of towns emerged when Menilek's generals established garrisons in suitable locations in order to maintain control of the occupied provinces. The presence of the governors and soldiers made such areas permanent areas of politico-economic and religious activities. Such centers of administration known as *katamas* (garrison towns) became centers of trade and eventually grew into towns. Towns including Gobba, Ticho, Gore, Arjo, etc were garrisons that grew into towns. During the Italian rule (1936-41), several of the above towns grew in size and other new towns evolved because of socio-economic and political developments of the period.

6.5. External Relations

6.5.1. Agreements and Treaties

One consequence of the *Zemene-Mesafint* was the end of the 'close door policy' that was introduced by Emperor Fasiladas (1632-1667). Thus, beginning from the early 1800s, regional rulers made independent foreign contacts and signed treaties. During the nineteenth century, the agents of these external relations were mainly travelers. Travelers came to Ethiopia and the Horn with the motives of adventure and scientific research. They were also sometimes involved in fostering friendship and trade relation on behalf of their governments. Some of them, however, came with covert mission of colonialism. Meanwhile, various rulers of Ethiopia and the Horn had also dispatched their own delegations to various countries of the world.

One of the earliest private travelers was Henry Salt who reached the court of *Ras* Wolde-Selassie of Tigray on 28 August 1805. He came for scientific reasons, but he claimed that his mission was to establish friendship between Great Britain and Ethiopia. He returned to Ethiopia in 1809 and concluded agreement with the *Ras*.

Several British travelers including Christian Kugler also arrived in the 1830s. Travelers from Germany like Eduard Ruppell (a scholar) arrived in 1846; Captain W.C. Harris, leading an official British mission visited Shewa. John Bell and Walter Plowden in the 1840s, the Italian Geographic Society in 1869 and the like arrived for trade relation and scientific purposes.

The result of these contacts was the agreement between *Negus* Sahle-Selassie of Shewa and British Captain W. Harris in 1841 as well as with the French Rochet d'Hericourt, in 1843. In addition, Walter Plowden also signed treaty with *Ras* Ali in 1849.

Furthermore, other regional lords had contacts with religious centers in the Middle East, particularly with Jerusalem. During the period, Egyptians threatened the Ethiopian religious community settlement at Deir Al-Sultan in Jerusalem. As a result, in the early 1850s, strong lords like *Ras* Ali and *Dejjazmach* Wube sent letters to Queen Victoria of England to request support against the Egyptians. External relations during the reign of Tewodros II seemed more elaborate and oriented towards obtaining western technology and military support to

defend against foreign aggression. As with his predecessors, Emperor Yohannes IV tried to create strong relations with Europeans. The major concerns of Emperor Yohannes IV were the restoration of the lost territories, the delimitation of boundaries and the defense of the sovereignty of the state against the threat and interference by foreign powers. When he confronted external challenge like Egypt, he tried to solve through negotiation than war. War was his last choice as he fought with Egypt in 1875/76 and Mahdists Sudan in 1889.

One of the major diplomatic relations Yohannes concluded was Hewett /Adwa Treaty. It was a treaty signed between the Emperor and the British Rear Admiral William Hewett on behalf of Egypt on 3 June 1884 at Adwa. The purpose was to safely evacuate Egyptian troops through Ethiopia who were trapped by the Mahdists troops along the Ethio-Sudanese border. In return, Bogos was to be restored to Ethiopia and the latter was to freely use Massawa for the transit of goods and firearms.

Based on the agreement, Emperor Yohannes facilitated the safe evacuation of Egyptian troops through his territory. Britain restored Bogos to Ethiopia. However, Britain secretly transferred Massawa from Egypt to Italy in February 1885. One consequence of the treaty was Mahdists' determination to avenge Yohannes that led to the battle of Metemma on 9 March 1889, which claimed his life.

In terms of diplomatic relations and repulsing external threats, Emperor Menilek II was more successful through maintaining the balance among powerful forces of the period. While he was king of Shewa, he established commercial relation with Italy that later helped him to acquire military equipment.

Menelik's relations with Italy reached its climax with the signing of the Wuchale Treaty. It was drafted by Count Pietro Antonelli and signed on 2 May 1889, at Wuchale, Wollo between Emperor Menilek II of Ethiopia and Antonelli on behalf of Prime Minister Crispi of Italy. The treaty has twenty articles and was written both in Amharic and Italian languages. When Ras Mokonnen visited Italy after the signing of the treaty, the Italians made him sign an additional convention, which introduced the phrase "effective occupation" of Italy to legitimize the territories that the Italians had come to occupy after the treaty. As a result,

based on the Italian version of Article XVII, Italy announced that all foreign powers had to deal with Ethiopia only through Italy. European powers gave recognition to this Italian claim except Russia. In January 1890, the Italian government formally declared Eritrea as its colony.

Italian action to colonize Ethiopia through a combination of tricky treaties, persuasion and subversive methods failed. This was because Menilek publicly abrogated the Wuchale Treaty in February 1893 and Tigrian lords including *Ras Mangasha Yohannes*, *Ras Sebhat Aragawi* and *Dajjach Hagos Tafari*, who the Italians were hoping to use, began to fight against the Italians collaborating with Emperor Menilek. Italian determination to occupy Ethiopia and Ethiopian resistance against colonialism led to the battle. Finally this led to the Battle of Adwa, where the Ethiopians won a decisive victory. After the victory of Adwa, different foreign countries opened their legations at Addis Ababa to establish relations on official basis.

Furthermore, Emperor Menilek made boundary agreements with the then neighboring colonial powers like French-Somaliland (the present day Djibouti) on 20 March 1897, with British-Somaliland (now Somaliland) on June 1897, with Anglo-Egyptian Sudan on 15 May 1902, with the Italian colony of Eritrea on 10 July 1900 and also with British East Africa (Kenya) in 1907 and Italian-Somaliland in 1908. These boundary agreements shaped modern Ethiopian boundary.

International politics of the twentieth century also shaped Ethiopia's foreign relations. For instance, during the First World War (1914-18) *Lij Iyasu* showed a tendency to side with the Central Powers (Germany, Austro-Hungary, and Ottoman Empire) believing that the defeat of the Allied powers (France and Britain) would allow Ethiopia to push Italy out of Eritrea and Somalia. He also befriended the Somali nationalist leader, Sayyid Mohammed Abdille Hassan, against Italy and Britain. Sayyid Mohammed Abdille Hassan (1864-1920) led the Somali against the European occupation. He tried to attract mass support through his Pan-Somali movement. In the history of the Somali, he is recognized as a forerunner of modern Somali nationalism.

One of the successes of Ethiopia's foreign relation in the early twentieth century was her admission to the League of Nations in 1923. A year later, Teferi made his grand European tour, which shaped his ideas of modernization. Ethiopia's entry into the League of Nations, however, did not save her from Italian invasion in 1935/36.

6. 5. 2. Major Battles Fought Against Foreign Aggressors and Patriotism

Ethiopian people fought several battles against foreign threats during the period under discussion. The following section discusses patriotism, determination and cooperation as well as the successes and limits of Ethiopian peoples in the course of defending their country.

The Battle of Dabarki (1848): Dabarki was fought between Kasa Hailu of Qwara and Egyptian forces in 1848. Although the forces led by Kasa Hailu lost the battle, the military imbalance particularly, the modern artillery and discipline of Egyptian troops gave him a lesson to modernize his military force, acquire modern technologies. This later initiated him to widen his vision and mission when he became emperor.

The Battle of Maqdela (1868): Tewodros II had early relation with Britain through two British citizens, Walter Plowden and John Bell. His main aim was to obtain help against foreign threats. In 1862, he sent a letter to Queen Victoria requesting assistance through Consul Cameron. Cameron came back to Ethiopia via Egypt without bringing any response. Suspecting him of plotting with Egypt, Tewodros imprisoned Captain Cameron and other Europeans. On learning of the imprisonment of the Europeans, Queen Victoria sent a letter through Hormuzd Rassam, which did not satisfy Tewodros.

After some communications, the British parliament decided to take military action. Subsequently, 32,000 troops led by Sir Robert Napier were sent through Massawa. This force reached Maqdela guided by *Dejazmach* Bezibiz Kassa of Tigray (later Emperor Yohannes). Although Wagshum Gobeze did not make any attempt to fight the British, he did not join them. On April 10, 1868, up to 8,000 Tewodros' soldiers including his general Gebriye were defeated by the British at the battle of Aroge. On April 13, 1868, Tewodros committed suicide at Maqdela. This was followed by the burning of his fortress and looting of manuscripts, religious and secular artifacts including his crown by the British troops.

The Battles of Gundet and Gura

In the nineteenth century, Egyptians showed a keen interest to occupy Northeast Africa with the ambition of controlling the source of the Nile. Following their occupation of the Sudan in 1821, they moved to occupy Ethiopia on several occasions. For instance, in 1875, Khedive Ismail Pasha sent his troops to invade Ethiopia in three directions. Mohammed Rauf Pasha led the Zeila front and the result was the occupation of the Harar Emirate between 1875 and 1885. Werner Munzinger, the architect of the whole of Ismail's scheme for invasion of Ethiopia, led about 500 Egyptian troops equipped with cannons and rocket tubes through Tajura. But, Munzinger and his troops were all killed by the Afars at the Battle of Odduma. Finally, Colonel Arendrup and Arakel Bey led another 2,000 well-armed troops through Massawa. Emperor Yohannes IV and Ras Alula mobilized about 20,000 forces and encountered the Egyptians at the Battle of Gundet (16 November 1875) where the Egyptian troops were severely defeated. Notwithstanding their setback, Egyptians again reorganized their forces and sent their army to invade Ethiopia. However, the Ethiopian forces again defeated them at the Battle of Gura (7–9 March, 1876).

It is important to understand that some Europeans and Americans were in the service of Egyptians. For instance, the architect of the whole of Ismail's plan, Werner Munzinger, was a Swiss born adventurer and former French Consul in Northeast Africa. Colonel Arendrup himself was a Danish Citizen, and General Charles Stone was fellow American.

The Battle of Dogali

During the late nineteenth century, Europeans had interest to control the Red Sea area. With the opening of the Suez Canal in 1869, the Red Sea region acquired great strategic and commercial importance. One of the colonial powers with interest in the Horn of Africa was Italy. The relations Italy had with the Horn began when an Italian private shipping company (Rubatino) bought the port of Assab from the local chiefs in 1869. In 1882, the port of Assab was transferred to the Italian government. In 1885, Britain secretly transferred Massawa from Egypt to Italy. By using these bases as springboard, Italy began to penetrate into northern Ethiopia. Subsequently, the Italian forces occupied Sa'ati, Aylet and Wia in the then Mereb Milash region. However, they were defeated decisively at the Battle of Dogali by Ras Alula

Engida, Emperor Yohannes's famous general and right hand man. Following this battle, Italy signed a Treaty of Neutrality with Menilek in October 1887 in a bid to isolate Emperor Yohannes.

The Battle of Metemma

As indicated above, the Hewett Treaty caused clashes between the Mahdist and Ethiopian forces that lasted from 1885 to 1889. The first clash was at Kufit between *Ras Alula* and *Uthman Digna* in September 1885. Initially, the Ethiopian force was victorious. In January 1887, Yohannes ordered *Nigus Tekle-Haymanot* of Gojjam to repulse the Mahdists. A year later, the Mahdists led by Abu Anja, defeated *Nigus Tekle-Haimanot's* troops at Sar- Wuha in Dembia. However, when Emperor Yohannes IV was in northern Ethiopia to check the Italian advance to Mereb Milash, he heard of the Mahdists advance up to Gondar. The Mahdists caused a lot of destruction on churches and monasteries, including the killing of the clergy and the laity. At this important juncture, *Nigus Menilek* and *Nigus Tekle-Haimanot* conspired against the emperor, instead of directly facing the Mahdists. As a result, Emperor Yohannes faced what can be called a triangular tension, namely the Italians in the north, the Mahdists in the west and northwest, and his two vassals in the center.

Later, in another direction, the Mahdists were defeated at Gute Dilli (in Najjo-Wallagga) by Menilek's commander *Ras Gobana Dache* on October 14, 1888. Emperor Yohannes made a national call:

የኢትዮጵያ ህዝብ ሆይ ኢትዮጵያ የተባለችዉ ሀገር፡ 1ኛ እናትህ ናት፤ 2ኛ ክብርህ ናት፤ 3ኛ ሚስትህ ናት፤ 4ኛ ልጅህ ናት፤ 5ኛ መቃብርህ ናት። እንግዲህ የእናትን ፍቅር፣ የዘወድን ክብር፣ የሚስትን የዋህነት፣ የልጅን ደስታ፣ የመቃብርን ከከባቲነት አስበህ ተነስ!

Literally, Oh! the people of Ethiopia,

The country called Ethiopia is firstly your mother, secondly your crown, thirdly your wife, fourthly your child, fifthly your grave. Accordingly, rise up understanding the love of a mother, honor of a crown, the goodness of a wife, the delight of having a child, and the shelter of a grave.

Hence, on March 9, 1889, the Emperor marched to Metemma where he died fighting the Mahdists. Evidently, it has to be noted here that internal divisions and acrimonies among

rulers would result in a huge cost to the country and its peoples. Among others, Maqdela and Metemma are very good testimonies.

The Battle of Adwa and Its Aftermath

The disagreement on the Wuchale Treaty finally led to the big battle between Ethiopia and Italian forces. This was because Italians were determined to colonize Ethiopia whereas Ethiopians were ready not to give in. To meet their intention, the Italians crossed the Mereb River, arrived at Adigrat, and proceeded to Emba-Alage. Following Emperor Menilek's proclamation for general mobilization, about 100,000 troops from every part of the country gathered at Wara-Illu (in today's South Wollo). People marched to the front irrespective of gender, regional, and ethnic differences to fight against the Italian aggression. The force led by *Fitawrari* Gebeyehu Gurmu defeated the Italians at Emba-Alage and forced them to retreat to Mekelle. In January 1896, under the leadership of *Ras* Mekonnen, the Ethiopian forces defeated Italians at Mekelle. At Mekelle, the Italians were brought under siege denying them of access to a water well which they used. The strategy was commonly called the "siege of Mekelle" and was considered to be designed by Empress Taytu. After some negotiations, the besieged Italian troops were set free and joined their compatriots at Adwa.

A month later, Ethiopian forces led by Emperor Menilek, Empress Tayitu and war generals like *Ras* Mikael, *Ras* Makonnen, *Ras* Alula, *Ras* Mangasha and *Negus* Tekle-Haymanot and others encountered the Italians at Adwa. The result of this battle was a decisive victory for Ethiopians but a huge blow to the Italians, which doomed their colonial ambition over Ethiopia. At this battle, about 8,000 Italian fighters were killed, 1,500 wounded and 3,000 were captured. On the Ethiopian side, about 4,000-6,000 troops are said to have been killed.

Consequently, Italy recognized the independence of Ethiopia by the treaty of Addis Ababa that was signed on October 26, 1896. A number of powers of the time (including Italy, France, Britain, Russia, the United States, Germany, Belgium, Turkey, and others) also recognized the independence of Ethiopia and opened their legations in Addis Ababa.

Despite different interpretations on the results of the battle of Adwa, the heroic national campaign, cooperation, and common successes of peoples of Ethiopia had a positive

implication for success and national integration. The victory assured independence and national pride. It has thus become a source of pride for Ethiopians, Africans and the black race in general.

Furthermore, the victory of Ethiopians at Adwa has had an enduring legacy in the relations between freedom fighters and colonizing powers. The victory of black people over white colonizers initiated entire Africans fighting against colonialism. The well-known Pan-Africanist, Marcus Garvey, inspired his followers in his “Back to Africa” movement with the success of Ethiopians. He used phrases like “Ethiopia thou land of our fathers” and Ethiopianism became a symbol of anti-colonial movements.

6. 5. 3. Italian Occupation (1936-41) and the Patriotic Resistance

A. Background

Following their defeat at Adwa in 1896, the Italians suspended their expansionist colonial policy in Northeast Africa for a short time. However, they were just waiting for the right time to fulfill their ambitions in any possible way. Italy eventually got its ideological strength in 1922, when Fascists led by Benito Mussolini held power. The Fascists were determined to restore the power and glory of ancient Roman Empire by avenging Italy’s shameful scar at Adwa.

Initially, Mussolini did not disclose his ambition against the sovereignty of Ethiopia rather he was playing diplomatic ‘cards’ till the coming of the ‘right time.’ To achieve their goal of occupation of Ethiopia, Italians followed two policies as was the case before the Battle of Adwa; ‘subversion’ and ‘rapprochement’. The policy of subversion aimed at affecting the unity of the empire via sowing dissatisfaction in Tigray, Begemdir, Gojjam and Wollo. This responsibility was entrusted to Corrado Zoli, the governor of Eritrea (1928-1930). The Italian legation in Addis Ababa, headed by Guiliano Cora led the policy of ‘rapprochement’, a pseudo reconciliation tactic which was trying to persuade the Ethiopian government to establish cordial relations between the two countries. For instance, the signing of the 1928 Italo-Ethiopian Treaty of Peace and Friendship was the manifestation of the success of the rapprochement policy. Here, beside their legation in Addis Ababa, the Italians had also

consulates in provincial towns such as Dessie, Adwa, Debre Markos and Gondar. These consulates played a significant role in propagating dissatisfaction and gathering vital military and political intelligence. In addition to such preparations, the Fascists were also able to get indirect diplomatic support from Britain and France for their colonial project in Ethiopia.

Here, although it is difficult to pinpoint one particular year when the decision was made by Mussolini to launch the intended invasion, 1932 appears to have been a crucial year. Mussolini who made all necessary preparations to launch an invasion against Ethiopia was only searching for a pretext, and then fortunately he found it in the Walwal incident. The Walwal Incident (5 December 1934) was the result of the post-Awa boundary agreement limitations: lack of demarcation on the ground and lack of effective administrative control in the frontier regions. However, the Italians refused to give back Walwal and even attacked the Ethiopian soldiers who were stationed nearby. Thus, this situation gave birth to the Walwal Incident.

Surprisingly, although the number of Ethiopians dead during this border clash was three times as high as the Italians, it was Italy, which demanded totally unreasonable apology and reparation from Ethiopia. Then, Ethiopia that refused to accept Italy's demand took the matter to the League of Nations and a period of diplomatic wrangling followed to resolve the dispute. However, in the meantime Mussolini, who already got the desired excuse, was finalizing his preparations to launch a total invasion.

B. The 1935 Invasion and After

After they completed their preparations, the Italians waged their aggression via two major fronts: the northern and the southern Front. The war was started in the northern Front when the Italians crossed the Mereb River on October 3, 1935 and launched a three pronged invasion and controlled Adigrat, Adwa and Mekelle. In January 1936, the Ethiopian counter offensive force marched north through three fronts. *Ras* Emiru Haile-Selassie led the western front, *Ras* Kasa Hailu (also commander of the entire northern front), *Ras* Seyum Mengesha led the central front, and *Ras* Mulugeta Yigezu (War Minister) led the eastern front.

On January 20, 1936, the Ethiopian army launched a major offensive against the Italians intending to isolate Mekelle, but failed to realize its objective due to lack of coordination

among the above-mentioned commanders. On January 24, the Ethiopian force lost to the Italians at the first Battle in Temben. This was followed by an attack on the Ethiopian force, which was stationed in what seemed to be an impregnable natural fortress of Amba-Aradom, to the south of Mekelle. The Italians scored yet another decisive victory in which the commander of the Ethiopian army, *Ras Mulugeta Yigezu*, lost his life. Besides modern weapons, the Italian force had superiority in the air. Moreover, the forces of *Ras Kasa* and *Ras Seyum* were outnumbered by the Italian troops. This resulted in another defeat at the Second Battle of Temben (27-29 February 1936). *Ras Kasa* and *Ras Seyum* narrowly escaped and joined the Emperor at Korem.

On the western front, the Ethiopian army under *Ras Emeru* put strong resistance against the advancing force of the Italians. Thanks to *Ras Emeru*'s better leadership quality, the number of death of Ethiopian soldiers was less than what it had been in the northern front.

A series of battles between the Ethiopian and Italian forces in the northern Front culminated in Maychew on 31 March 1936. Although the Ethiopian army (especially members of the *Kebur Zebegna*) under the command of the Emperor put strong resistance against the Italians, they were not able to conclude the battle with victory. Many Ethiopian soldiers lost their lives from ground and air bombardment during the battle. Then the Italian forces controlled Dessie and Addis Ababa on 4 April 1936 and 5 May 1936, respectively.

The Ethiopian army in the Southern Front was better equipped and well led. *Ras Desta Damtew* (in the south) and *Dejazmach Nesibu Zamanuel* (in the southeast) were leaders of the Ethiopian troops in this Front.

The Ethiopian army lost to the Italians at two major battles in the Southern Front: Qorahe (November 1935) and Genale Dorya (12-14 January 1936). In the ensuing battles, the *Askaris* (recruited from Eritrea) deserted the Italians and joined the Ethiopian force which boosted the moral of *Ras Desta*'s troops. *Ras Desta* continued to challenge the Italians until he was captured and executed in early 1937. The number of soldiers the Italians lost during the fighting in the Southern Front was larger than the North, which slowed their advance to the center; Badoglio entered Addis Ababa before Graziani even crossed Harar.

On 2 May 1936, the Emperor fled the country and three days later the Italians entered Addis Ababa. Between Haile Selassie's departure and the Italian entry, Addis Ababa was beset by burning of buildings, looting and random shooting. The major targets of the violence were the rich, foreigners and the imperial palace. Many foreigners saved their lives by taking refuge in foreign legations.

Here, the entry of the Italian forces into the capital in the middle of such chaos was a relief for both the foreigners and the natives since the Italians were able to bring peace and order to the city. At this juncture, some scholars suggested that the Italians deliberately delayed their entry so that the people of the city would consider them as 'angels' of peace, and easily accept their rule. Anyway, after their control of the capital, Marshal Badoglio immediately reported the situation to Mussolini. Benito Mussolini announced to the people of Italy and the world about their control of Ethiopia using the phrase "Ethiopia is Italian!"

The Italians immediately merged Ethiopia with their colonies of Italian Somaliland and Eritrea. Then, they named the combination of their colonies Italian East Africa (IEA) or *Africa Orientale Italiana* (AOI). The newly formed Italian East Africa had six administrative regional divisions that replaced former international boundaries. These were: Eritrea (including Tigray) with its capital at Asmara; Amhara (including Begemidr, Gojjam, Wollo and Northern Shewa) with its capital at Gondar; Oromo and Sidama (including Southern and Southwestern provinces) with its capital at Jimma; Eastern Ethiopia with its capital at Harar; Somalia (including Ogaden) with its capital at Mogadishu; Addis Ababa (later changed to Shewa), the capital of the entire Italian East Africa.

During the Italian occupation of Ethiopia, the following Italians served as governors of Italian East Africa successively: Marshal Badoglio (till the end of May 1936), Marshal Graziani (till February 1937), and finally Amadeo Umberto d'Aosta (the Duke of Aosta).

Generally, a top-heavy bureaucracy and corruption characterized the Italian administration of IEA. For instance, the last governor of IEA, the Duke of Aosta himself characterized 50% of his officials as inept and 25% as thieves. Marshal Badoglio himself reportedly pocketed about 1,700,000 Maria Theresa Thalers confiscated from the Bank of Ethiopia, in the immediate aftermath of the conquest. In the economic respect, the Italians weakened and

destroyed non-Italian foreign firms and replaced them with governmental enterprises that controlled the industry, trade and agriculture.

The Italians were relatively successful in the sectors of trade and industry as compared to the agricultural sector. For instance, they planned to settle Italian farmers in selected Ethiopian areas such as Wegera, Chercher and Jimma. However, their agricultural plan failed (they only accomplished 10%) due to their failure to secure the control of the rural areas due to the patriotic movement.

As indicated above, the Italian administrative control was largely confined to urban areas due to the strong patriotic resistance. Thus; their legacy was also largely reflected in the towns than the rural areas, which were actually out of Italian effective rule. Generally, the legacy of the Italian rule can be summarized in the following brief points:

- Architecture- the Italians left an indelible mark in towns such as Addis Ababa, Jimma, Adwa, Gondar, Desse, Harar, Asmara, Mogadishu and others.
- Introduction of urban facilities like clean water and electricity;
- Social legacies (expansion of prostitution, adoption of European habits-including eating and dressing styles, and adoption of Italian words);
- The consolidation of cash economy;
- Road construction and development of motor transport;
- The sense of division, deliberately fostering ethnic and religious tensions etc.

C. The Patriotic Resistance Movement

The five-year Italian occupation (1936-41) was not a smooth experience. Rather, the Ethiopian peoples opposed them in a number of ways. Among others, the patriots gave them hard times largely in rural areas. They continuously harassed them. Ethiopian patriots continued their resistance in almost all regions and by all ethnic groups of the empire with varying degree of intensification. The first phase of resistance was the continuation of the war itself. Among the highlights of this phase was the resistance waged by three commanders of the Southern Front, *Ras Desta Damtew*, *Dejjach Beyene Merid* and *Dejjach Gebre Maryam Gari*. An extension of this phase was a five pronged assault on the capital in the summer of 1936. The campaign involved two sons of *Ras Kasa Hailu* (*Asfawesen* and

Aberra), the veteran of Adwa *Dejjach* Balcha Safo, *Balambaras* (later *Ras*) Abebe Aregay, and *Dejjach* Fikre-Mariam Yinnadu.

However, it failed because of lack of effective means of transportation and radio communication. *Abune* Petros, the Bishop of Wollo, who was the spirit behind the patriots was executed and became a martyr of the resistance. The killing of the bishop was unheard of in Ethiopia and shocked the nation, arousing the indignation of the people, especially the clergy.

The second phase covers from 1937 to the end of the Italian occupation in 1941. On 19 February 1937, two young Ethiopian patriots, Abreha Deboch and Moges Asgedom, hurled a bomb at Graziani in the Genete-Le'ul palace compound at Sidist Kilo, wounding him seriously and killing some others. This was followed by a reign of terror waged by the Black Shirts; who chopped off heads, burnt down houses with their inhabitants, and disemboweled thousands in Addis Ababa. According to Ethiopian official accounts, about 30,000 Ethiopians of different ages, classes and sex were killed in three days' campaign. Special targets of the Fascist terror were educated Ethiopians (including many members of the Black Lion Organization). The EOC also became a target. For instance, on 21 May 1937, in the monastery of Debre Libanos alone, 297 monks were executed. The elimination of the intelligentsia was to create 'the missing generation' in Ethiopia's intellectual and political history.

This Fascist terror marked the transition from the conventional patriotic resistance to guerrilla warfare that could eventually weaken the enemy forces. Different guerrilla units kept the Italian troops under constant harassment.

As the Fascist regime became intolerable to Ethiopians, there also arose women who led their own army in the guerrilla wars, like *Woizero* Lekyelesh Beyan, whose career as a guerrilla fighter ended in January 1941, when she was captured after an Italian air bombardment.

Woizero Kebedech Seyoum (a daughter of *Ras* Seyum Mengesha and the wife of *Dejazmach* Abera Kasa), started her patriotic activity before the fall of Addis Ababa to the

Italians. Thus, when her husband was fighting in the northern front, she maintained peace and order in the province of Salale representing her husband.

Although it lacked coordination, patriotic resistance to Italian rule took place in the country in numerous forms and tenacity. There was no unified command structure. In most provinces of the country, similar acts of resistance were observed. Eritreans too were joining the resistance in big numbers. A comprehensive list and explanation on each patriot in a module such as this would not be possible.

However, hereunder an attempt has been made to list a few patriots that we think can represent different parts of Ethiopia. *Dejjazmach* Umar Samatar, Colonel Abdisa Aga, *Dejjazmach* Belay Zeleke, *Dejjazmach* Gebrehiwot Meshesha, *Dejjazmach* Abbbai Kahsay, *Woizero* Shewareged Gedle, Zeray Dires, Colonel Jagama Kello, *Woizero* Sinidu Gebru, *Ras* Amoraw Wubneh, *Lij* Haile Mariam Mamo, *Ras* Abebe Aregay, *Dejjazmach* Habte Mariam, Colonel Belay Haile-ab, Major Matias Gameda, Captain Yosef Nesibu, *Blatta* Takele Wolde-Hawaryat, *Dejjach* Geresu Duki, Bekele Woya, etc.

The struggle continued but it suffered from serious internal weakness. The resistance was handicapped by the Ethiopian collaborators called the *Banda* who exercised their corrosive activities in different areas. Another weakness of the resistance movement was that it was divided and that there was no one national organization to coordinate the activities of the many patriotic groups dispersed in many parts of the country. Relations between guerrilla groups were characterized by parochialism and jealousy. Some guerrilla groups spent more time fighting one another than attacking the declared enemy.

Despite these weaknesses, the patriots carried on a persistent resistance against Italian fascism, until suddenly they got external support from Britain in 1941. Ethiopian struggle for independence was associated with World War II, when Italy declared war on France and Britain on 10 June 1940. Mussolini decided to enter the war on the side of Germany in the hope of securing outside support; the internationalization of the conflict was a good opportunity. For Haile-Sellassie too, the situation was important. His requests for assistance

were finally answered by the British government that decided to drive out Italians from East Africa.

On July 12, 1940, London recognized the Emperor as a full ally. The British launched a three-pronged attack on the Italians. In the north, General William Platt led the forces that attacked the Italians in Eritrea. In January 1941, Colonel Sandford and Major Wingate accompanied the Emperor from the Sudan into Gojjam at the head of British and Ethiopian troops called the Gedeon force. General Cunningham led the attack from Kenya. The advances were rapid largely due to the demoralization that the patriots had caused on the Italian forces. Emperor Haile-Selassie entered Addis Ababa on 5 May 1941, exactly five years after Italian entry to the capital.